The center and the ends of the elephant random walk with rare reversals

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Abstract

In the elephant random walk each step copies a uniformly chosen earlier step and reverses it with probability ε. We let ε tend to zero as the number of steps N grows, with $N\varepsilon$ of order $\log N$. The number of steps that disagree with the first step is approximated by a truncated Luria–Delbrück law, with an explicit bound on each mass error. After centering and scaling, it satisfies a local limit theorem with the Landau density and an explicit rate. These bounds locate every mode of the walk near one of its two ends. For even N we also ask when the origin is as likely as each end. This crossing is unique, and its expected reversal count is $2\log N - \log\log N - \log 16 + o(1)$, about twice that of the persistent random walk. We give explicit bounds on the relative error of the approximation $4\varepsilon/(N+2)$ for the origin probability. To first order, reaching the origin requires one reversal among the first few steps. For every N and $\varepsilon < \frac{1}{2}$, the second difference of the endpoint law changes sign at most four times. At the crossing, the origin is the unique interior minimum for every sufficiently large even N, and a computer-assisted proof gives the same conclusion for every even N from eight to 2000. The interval between these two ranges remains open.

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1 Introduction

In the elephant random walk of Schütz and Trimper [1], each step copies a uniformly chosen earlier step and reverses its sign with probability ε. The first step is fair. Put $x = N\varepsilon$. We study $x \asymp \log N$, so reversals become rarer even though their expected number $x - \varepsilon$ grows. Most limit theorems instead fix ε [4, 5, 6, 7, 8].

The number of steps disagreeing with the first is the resistant-cell count in Bokes, Hlubinová and Singh's reversible fluctuation assay [19], with equal switching probabilities. Their first-switch and Pólya-urn calculation already gives the first-order center coefficient $4/(N+2)$ [19, Eqs. (6)–(10)], and their random-start approximation uses two Landau densities [19, Eqs. (58)–(60)]. Our contribution is quantitative, namely an explicit mass-error bound for the truncated Luria–Delbrück approximation, a Landau local limit theorem with a rate, and rigorous crossing and shape results for the walk.

For even N, when is the origin as likely as each endpoint $\pm N$? Near $\varepsilon = 0$ the endpoints win, while at $\varepsilon = \frac{1}{2}$ the steps are independent and the origin wins. We prove that they cross exactly once and locate the crossing at $x = 2\log N - \log\log N - \log 16 + o(1)$. The persistent walk, which copies the last step rather than a uniform earlier step, crosses at about $\log N$ switches [10]. That comparison originates in Kagey's Galton-board problem [9], so we call the possible counts of right steps bins.

For comparison of conventions, the original memory parameter is $1-\varepsilon$, the parameter a of [7] is $1-2\varepsilon$, and the broadcasting flip probability is ε. The broadcasting tree representation is recalled in Lemma 3.1 [2, 3].

1.1 Setting and notation

The walk takes N steps $X_1, \dots, X_N \in \{+1, -1\}$, where $+1$ means right. Let $A_N = \#\{i \le N : X_i = +1\}$ be the number of right steps, and write $P_N(k) = \mathbb{P}(A_N = k)$ for the probability of bin k. Unless we say otherwise the first step is fair, $\mathbb{P}(X_1 = +1) = \frac{1}{2}$, and the rules treat the two directions alike, so $P_N(k) = P_N(N-k)$. We write $\mathbb{P}_+$ and $\mathbb{E}_+$ for probability and expectation given $X_1 = +1$. For even N we put $h = N/2$ and call $C_N = P_N(h)$ the center and $E_N = P_N(N) = P_N(0)$ the end. Whenever C_N appears, N is even. The crossing is the value of the parameter at which $C_N = E_N$. All logarithms are natural, $L = \log N$, $H_k = \sum_{j \le k} 1/j$ is the k-th harmonic number, and γ is Euler's constant. Limits, $O(\cdot)$ and $o(\cdot)$ refer to $N \to \infty$, over even N when C_N appears. The constants implied by $O(\cdot)$ are absolute unless we name what they depend on.

The elephant walk (Definition 2.1) has the reversal probability $\varepsilon \in (0,1)$ and $x = N\varepsilon$. Its crossing is ε_N, and $x_N = N\varepsilon_N$. The symbols that only one section uses are defined in that section, where they first appear.

1.2 Main results

Theorem 1.2 is the main approximation tool. We first state the center and crossing bounds, then the bulk and shape results.

Theorem 1.1 (the center and the crossing)**.** *Let $N \ge 2$ be even.*

(a) The ratio C_N/E_N is strictly increasing in $\varepsilon \in (0,1)$, and the crossing ε_N exists, is unique and lies in $(0, \frac{1}{2})$ (Proposition 2.3).

(b) For $0 < \varepsilon < \frac{1}{2}$ we have $C_N \ge \frac{4\varepsilon}{N+2}(1-2\varepsilon)$. If $\varepsilon(1+\log N) \le \frac{1}{100}$, then $C_N \le \frac{4\varepsilon}{N+2}\, N^{2\varepsilon} e^{5200\varepsilon}$ (Theorem 2.6, whose constant 5200 uses an enclosure in ball arithmetic).

(c) As $N \to \infty$ over even N, the crossing satisfies $x_N + \log x_N = 2\log N - \log 8 + O(\log^2 N/N)$, and so

$$x_N = 2\log N - \log\log N - \log 16 + O\Big(\frac{\log\log N}{\log N}\Big)$$

(Theorem 2.7).

So $C_N = \frac{4\varepsilon}{N+2}(1 + O(\varepsilon \log N))$ when $\varepsilon \log N$ is small, and the error factor is $1 + O(\log^2 N/N)$ at the crossing. For the persistent walk with switch probability q, the crossing has $T = Nq$ close to $\log N$, and Theorem S1.7 of Online Resource 1 compares the two crossings to the next order.

For the rest of the law let M_N be the number of steps that disagree with the first step. Its law $f_N(m) = \mathbb{P}(M_N = m)$ does not depend on X_1, and $P_N(k) = \frac{1}{2}[f_N(N-k) + f_N(k)]$ (Lemma 2.2).

Let CP_N be the law of $\sum_{d=1}^{N-1} d\,\mathcal{N}_d$, where the $\mathcal{N}_d$ are independent Poisson variables with means $x/(d(d+1))$. Put $\lambda_m = (m - x\log x)/x$, and let

$$f_L(\lambda) = \frac{1}{2\pi}\int_{-\infty}^{\infty} e^{-i\lambda t} e^{B(t)}\,dt, \qquad B(t) = -it\log|t| - \frac{\pi}{2}|t|,$$

be the Landau density.

Theorem 1.2 (the bulk)**.** *Suppose $x \to \infty$ and $x^3 \log^2 N/N \to 0$. Uniformly over integers $m \geq 0$,*

$$\bigl|x f_N(m) - f_L(\lambda_m)\bigr| = O\Bigl(\frac{1+\log x}{x} + \frac{x^3\log^2 N}{N}\Bigr),$$

and $(M_N - x\log x)/x$ converges in law to the density f_L. Theorems 3.8 and 3.9 give explicit finite-N bounds. The density has a unique mode λ_{L} with $-0.22278299 < \lambda_{\mathrm{L}} < -0.22278297$ (Lemma 3.10, computer-assisted). For $\log N \leq x \leq 2\log N$ and all sufficiently large N, every mode $a^* \geq N/2$ of P_N satisfies

$$\bigl|N - a^* - x\log x - \lambda_{\mathrm{L}} x\bigr| \leq K\sqrt{x\log x},$$

and the same bound holds for every mode of f_N in place of $N - a^*$ (Corollary 3.11). We do not compute K.

So at the crossing the law of A_N has a hump near each end, about $x\log x - 0.2228\,x$ bins from it. The final position is $2A_N - N$, so in physical distance each hump is twice as far from $\pm N$. For the shape of the law between the humps let $D_N(a) = P_N(a+1) - 2P_N(a) + P_N(a-1)$ be its second difference, and for a mode $a^* \geq N/2$ of P_N put $m^* = N - a^*$.

Theorem 1.3 (the shape)**.** *For $N \geq 3$ and $0 < \varepsilon < \frac{1}{2}$, delete zeros from the signs of D_N and merge equal neighbors. The resulting pattern is a subsequence of $(+,-,+,-,+)$ (Theorem 3.18). At the crossing, P_N is not unimodal for every even $N \geq 8$ (Proposition 3.7, computer-assisted). For all sufficiently large N, even or odd, and uniformly for $\log N \leq x \leq 2\log N$, it is strictly convex between the humps, and at the even crossing the center is its unique interior minimum (Theorem 3.21, Corollary 3.23). The thresholds are not computed. Certified computations give the crossing convexity for even $6 \leq N \leq 2000$ and the unique interior minimum for even $8 \leq N \leq 2000$ (Propositions 3.24 and 3.26).*

For the even N above 2000 and below the eventual thresholds both conclusions are open (Conjecture 3.14 and Remark 3.27). The second would follow from the first by Lemma 3.22 whenever each mode lies within $(N-2)/4$ of the nearer end.

The three computational inputs are described in Section 4, with the result each one supports. The tables and figures illustrate the theorems and are not used in their proofs.

Why twice as many reversals? An endpoint has mass about $\frac{1}{2}e^{-x}$. In the persistent walk, let q be the switch probability and $T = Nq$. Its runs have typical length N/T, and the right-step count spreads over about $N/\sqrt{T}$ bins. Its central mass is of order $\sqrt{T}/N$, which balances e^{-T} at $T \approx \log N$. An elephant reversal instead starts a family of descendants, governed by Pólya's urn. Reaching the middle requires an early reversal whose family occupies about half the walk. This costs order ε, and the exact middle costs another $1/N$. Thus the center has mass about $4\varepsilon/N = 4x/N^2$, balancing the endpoint at $x \approx 2\log N$. Most of the roughly $2\log N$ reversals there occur too late to produce a large family.

1.3 Prior work

Fixed-parameter limits for the elephant walk are well developed [4, 5, 6]. Guérin, Laulin, Raschel and Simon prove conditional unimodality [7, Section 2, proof of Theorem 1.1]. Trinas and Valle's superdiffusive local limit and study of log-concavity [8, Theorem 3.1 and Eq. (4.10)] also fix the parameter. Engländer and Volkov's coin-turning walk instead switches at time n with probability p_n. For $p_n = a/n$ eventually, its occupation fraction tends to $\mathrm{Beta}(a, a)$ [13, Section 4, Theorem 1]. We vary the reversal probability with the final length, not with time within one walk.

Kürsten's percolation coupling [11] copies a parent with probability $1 - 2\varepsilon$ and otherwise gives the new vertex a fair sign. Baur and Bertoin [14] give the urn connection. Our regime is strongly supercritical in Baur's classification [12], following Bertoin [15]. These works describe cluster sizes; Baur's Corollary 1 gives a Poisson limit for the largest nonroot clusters. Miyazaki and Takei obtain related root-cluster limits via the minimal elephant walk [16, Theorems 2.3, 2.4 and Section 2.3]. They do not estimate the exact central mass in our regime.

Without truncation, our compound Poisson law is the Lea–Coulson Luria–Delbrück law. Kessler and Levine describe its small-parameter profile and Landau limit [17, Eqs. (14), (18), (19)], as well as the dip threshold and mode near $\mu N(\log \mu N - 0.22)$ [17, Section 2]. Möhle proves the stable limit and density formulas [20, Theorem 4.1 and Corollary 4.1]; his Corollary 4.2 gives a uniform lattice local limit for integer parameters, without a rate. Schweinsberg [21] and Bertoin [22] obtain the same stable law for root-cluster fluctuations at retention $1 - c/\log n$. We add truncation at $N - 1$, an explicit local rate and transfer to the elephant law, from which its dip and mode estimates follow.

Broadcasting papers study reconstruction of the root color from the terminal tree [2, 3]; color-count limits and martingale error bounds are also available [23, 24]. Here the center is the probability of a color tie, relevant to majority-vote error, with the flip probability tending to zero. Gut and Stadtmüller's count [25, (1.5)] has next-step probability pk/n, whereas ours has $\varepsilon + (1 - 2\varepsilon)k/n$, so their chain cannot leave zero. The irreversible mutation expansion of Kessler and Levine [18, Eqs. (10), (13), (14)] has the same first derivative at $\varepsilon = 0$ as our law, but not our uniform relative bound at $N\varepsilon \asymp \log N$. We found no such central estimate in the literature reviewed.

1.4 Organization

Section 2 proves the crossing theorem, using the center bounds of Appendix A. Section 3 treats the bulk, modes and convexity. The compound Poisson and Landau proofs remain in Appendix C; Appendix B states the auxiliary family estimates. Section 4 describes the numerical and formal checks. Online Resource 1 contains the proofs of the family estimates and second-difference lemmas, as well as the second-order crossing, tail and odd-N results. Its auxiliary proofs support the main theorems and form part of the material to be refereed.

2 The elephant walk and its crossing

We reduce the elephant walk to a counting chain and prove that the crossing is unique. We then compute the center to first order in ε, bound it from both sides, and locate the crossing.

Definition 2.1 (elephant walk)**.** Fix $0 < \varepsilon < 1$. Let X_1 be uniform on $\{\pm 1\}$. For $t \geq 1$ let U_t be uniform on $\{1, \ldots, t\}$, and put $X_{t+1} = X_{U_t}$ with probability $1 - \varepsilon$ and $X_{t+1} = -X_{U_t}$ with probability ε. All these choices are independent. We call the event $X_{t+1} = -X_{U_t}$ a flip. As in

Section 1.1, $A_N = \#\{i \le N : X_i = +1\}$ and $P_N(k) = \mathbb{P}(A_N = k)$. The crossing ε_N is the value of ε with $C_N = E_N$ (it exists and is unique by Proposition 2.3), and $x_N = N\varepsilon_N$.

A flip is what the introduction called a reversal. Given the first step, all that matters is how many steps disagree with it. So let M_t be the number of $i \le t$ with $X_i \ne X_1$, and put

$$r_t(b) = \varepsilon + (1-2\varepsilon)\frac{b}{t}, \qquad f_N(m) = \mathbb{P}_+(M_N = m).$$

Lemma 2.2. *The process $(M_t)_{t\ge1}$ is a Markov chain with $M_1 = 0$ and $\mathbb{P}(M_{t+1} = b+1 \mid M_t = b) = r_t(b) = 1 - \mathbb{P}(M_{t+1} = b \mid M_t = b)$, and it is independent of X_1. For $0 \le k \le N$, $P_N(k) = \frac{1}{2}[f_N(N-k) + f_N(k)]$. In particular $C_N = f_N(h)$, $E_N = \frac{1}{2}(1-\varepsilon)^{N-1}$, and $P_N(k) = P_N(N-k)$.*

Proof. Given $X_1, \dots, X_t$, the copied step X_{U_t} differs from X_1 with probability M_t/t. So $X_{t+1} \ne X_1$ with conditional probability $(1-\varepsilon)M_t/t + \varepsilon(1 - M_t/t) = r_t(M_t)$. This depends only on M_t and not on X_1, which proves the first claim. On $\{X_1 = +1\}$ we have $A_N = N - M_N$, and on $\{X_1 = -1\}$ we have $A_N = M_N$. Averaging over X_1 gives the formula for $P_N(k)$, which does not change under $k \mapsto N-k$. Finally $M_N \le N-1$, so $f_N(N) = 0$, and $f_N(0) = \prod_{t=1}^{N-1}(1 - r_t(0)) = (1-\varepsilon)^{N-1}$. □

So the end is that of the persistent walk with switch probability ε. More flips always raise the center relative to the end.

Proposition 2.3. *Let $N \ge 2$ and $1 \le k \le N-1$. Then $f_N(k)/f_N(0)$ and $P_N(k)/E_N$ are strictly increasing in $\varepsilon \in (0,1)$. In particular C_N/E_N is strictly increasing, the crossing ε_N exists and is unique, and $\varepsilon_N < \frac{1}{2}$. Also $P_N(k) \ge 2E_N$ for $\varepsilon \ge \frac{1}{2}$, and in particular $C_N \ge 2E_N$ there.*

Proof. We compare each path of M with the path that never flips, one step at a time. The probability of a path of M is a product of $N-1$ factors, namely $r_s(b_s)$ for an up step at time s and $1 - r_s(b_s)$ otherwise, where b_s is the state at time s. The path that never flips has probability $f_N(0) = (1-\varepsilon)^{N-1}$, which is one factor $1-\varepsilon$ for each step. So we divide each factor by $1-\varepsilon$. With $y = b_s/s \in [0,1)$ the two kinds of factors become $\frac{\varepsilon+(1-2\varepsilon)y}{1-\varepsilon}$ and $1 - y\frac{1-2\varepsilon}{1-\varepsilon}$, whose derivatives in ε are $\frac{1-y}{(1-\varepsilon)^2} > 0$ and $\frac{y}{(1-\varepsilon)^2} \ge 0$. Both factors are positive, since $r_s(b_s) = \varepsilon(1-y) + (1-\varepsilon)y$ lies strictly between 0 and 1. So the ratio for each path is nondecreasing in ε, and it is strictly increasing if the path has an up step. Summing over the paths with $k \ge 1$ up steps proves the claim for $f_N(k)/f_N(0)$. By Lemma 2.2, $P_N(k)/E_N = [f_N(k) + f_N(N-k)]/f_N(0)$, and both k and $N-k$ are at least 1. So the claim for $P_N(k)/E_N$ follows.

It remains to locate the crossing. The ratio C_N/E_N is continuous and strictly increasing in ε. As $\varepsilon \to 0$ it tends to 0, since $C_N \to 0$ (at $\varepsilon = 0$ the chain never leaves 0) and $E_N \to \frac{1}{2}$. For $\varepsilon \ge \frac{1}{2}$ every $r_s(b)$ and every $1 - r_s(b)$ lies in $[1-\varepsilon, \varepsilon]$, so each path of M has probability at least $(1-\varepsilon)^{N-1} = 2E_N$. Every m with $0 \le m \le N-1$ is the end of some path, so $f_N(m) \ge 2E_N$. Both k and $N-k$ lie in $\{1, \dots, N-1\}$, so $P_N(k) = \frac{1}{2}[f_N(N-k) + f_N(k)] \ge 2E_N$, and in particular $C_N \ge 2E_N$ there. So the ratio equals 1 at exactly one ε, and this ε lies in $(0, \frac{1}{2})$. □

2.1 First order, one early flip

When $\varepsilon = 0$ the chain M never leaves 0. After a first flip, and to first order in ε, it is Pólya's urn.

Lemma 2.4 (Pólya's urn)**.** *Let $2 \le v \le N$. At time v an urn holds one ball of one color and $v-1$ of the other. At each time $k = v, \dots, N-1$ we draw a ball uniformly and return it with one more ball of its color. Let $\beta_v(d)$ be the probability that at time N there are d balls of the first*

color. Then $\beta_v(d) = \binom{N-d-1}{v-2}/\binom{N-1}{v-1}$ *for* $1 \le d \le N-v+1$*, and* $\beta_v(d) = 0$ *for other* d*. Also* β_v *is nonincreasing on* $\{1, \dots, N-v+1\}$ *and* $\sum_d d\,\beta_v(d) = N/v$*. For* $1 \le d \le N-1$*,*

$$\sum_{v=2}^{N} \beta_v(d) = \frac{N}{d(d+1)}, \qquad \sum_{v=2}^{N} (v-2)\,\beta_v(d) = \frac{2N(N-d-1)}{d(d+1)(d+2)}.$$

Proof. We compute the probability of one order of the draws and count the orders. At time k the urn holds k balls. So if s of them are of the first color, the next draw is of that color with probability s/k. Take one order of the $N-v$ draws in which i draws are of the first color. The draws of the first color contribute the numerators $1, 2, \dots, i$, the other draws contribute $v-1, v, \dots, N-i-2$, and the denominators are $v, v+1, \dots, N-1$. So this order has probability $\frac{i!\,(v-1)v\cdots(N-i-2)}{v(v+1)\cdots(N-1)} = \frac{(v-1)\,i!\,(N-i-2)!}{(N-1)!}$, whatever the order is. There are $\binom{N-v}{i}$ orders. With $d = i+1$ this gives $\beta_v(d) = a_d(v-1)\binom{N-v}{d-1}$ with $a_d = \frac{(d-1)!(N-d-1)!}{(N-1)!}$, and writing out the factorials shows that this is $\binom{N-d-1}{v-2}/\binom{N-1}{v-1}$. From the last form, $\beta_v(d)/\beta_v(d-1) = 1 - \frac{v-2}{N-d} \le 1$ for $2 \le d \le N-v+1$, so β_v is nonincreasing on its support. The fraction of balls of the first color is a martingale that starts at $1/v$. So the mean number of such balls at time N is N/v.

For the two sums we use the first form of $\beta_v(d)$ and put $i = N-v$, so that $v-1 = \binom{N-1-i}{1}$ and $(v-1)(v-2) = 2\binom{N-1-i}{2}$. The Chu–Vandermonde identity says that $\sum_i \binom{i}{a}\binom{N-1-i}{b} = \binom{N}{a+b+1}$ (sort the subsets of $\{1, \dots, N\}$ of size $a+b+1$ by their element number $a+1$, which we call $i+1$). With $a = d-1$ and $b = 1, 2$ it shows that the two sums are $a_d\binom{N}{d+1}$ and $2a_d\binom{N}{d+2}$, and these are the values in the statement. □

We need some more notation. Let $V_s(b)$ be the chance of ending at the center from state b at time s. We define it by the backward recursion $V_N(b) = \mathbf{1}\{b = h\}$ and $V_s(b) = r_s(b)V_{s+1}(b+1) + (1 - r_s(b))V_{s+1}(b)$ for $s < N$. So $V_s(b) = \mathbb{P}_+(M_N = h \mid M_s = b)$ whenever $\mathbb{P}_+(M_s = b) > 0$, and $V_s(b)$ is a polynomial in ε. In particular it is defined at $\varepsilon = 0$, without conditioning on an event of probability zero. For $1 \le t \le h$ let

$$\pi_t = \beta_{t+1}(h) = \frac{t}{N-t}\prod_{i=1}^{t-1}\frac{h-i}{N-i}, \qquad c_1 = \sum_{t=1}^{h}\pi_t, \qquad w_t = \frac{\pi_t}{c_1},$$

so that $(w_t)_{1 \le t \le h}$ is a probability vector.

The first-order coefficient in part (b) below is known. With both switching probabilities equal to ε and one sensitive cell at the start, the number of resistant cells in the reversible fluctuation assay of Bokes, Hlubinová and Singh [19, Section 2 and Eq. (1)] is our chain M. They condition on the first switch and use Pólya's urn, as we do, and their first-order formula [19, Eqs. (6)–(10)] gives $\varepsilon N/(m(m+1))$ as the part of $f_N(m)$ of first order in ε, which is $\frac{4\varepsilon}{N+2}$ at $m = h$. We include the short proof because the decomposition (a) and the weights (c) are what the uniform bounds of Theorem 2.6 and Appendix A start from.

Proposition 2.5 (first order, as in [19, Eqs. (6)–(10)])**.** *Let* $N \ge 2$ *be even.*

(a) The center is $C_N = \sum_{t=1}^{h} \varepsilon(1-\varepsilon)^{t-1}V_{t+1}(1)$*.*

(b) The center C_N *is a polynomial in* ε *with* $C_N(0) = 0$ *(extended as a polynomial to* $\varepsilon = 0$*). At* $\varepsilon = 0$ *we have* $V_{t+1}(1) = \pi_t$*, and* $C_N'(0) = c_1 = \frac{4}{N+2}$ *exactly.*

(c) The weights satisfy $\sum_t w_t t = 3 - \frac{6}{h+2}$*, and* $w_t \le 2t2^{-t}$ *for* $1 \le t \le h$*.*

Proof. (a) We condition on the time of the first flip. Under $\mathbb{P}_+$ the first flip happens at step $t+1$ exactly when $M_s = 0$ for $s \le t$ and $M_{t+1} = 1$. Since $r_s(0) = \varepsilon$, this has probability $(1-\varepsilon)^{t-1}\varepsilon$, and by the Markov property the chain then ends at h with probability $V_{t+1}(1)$. A path with no flip ends at $0 \neq h$. So C_N is the sum of $\varepsilon(1-\varepsilon)^{t-1}V_{t+1}(1)$ over $1 \le t \le N-1$. Only $t \le h$ contribute. Indeed at time $t+1$ there are t steps equal to X_1, this number never decreases, and at the center it is h. So $V_{t+1}(1) = 0$ for $t > h$.

(b) Every transition probability is affine in ε, so C_N and $V_{t+1}(1)$ are polynomials in ε. By (a), $C_N(0) = 0$ and $C_N'(0) = \sum_t V_{t+1}(1)|_{\varepsilon=0}$. At $\varepsilon = 0$ we have $r_s(b) = b/s$. So from time $t+1$ on, M counts the balls of the first color in the urn of Lemma 2.4 with $v = t+1$, and $V_{t+1}(1) = \beta_{t+1}(h) = \pi_t$. Since $\beta_v(h) = 0$ for $v > h+1$, Lemma 2.4 with $d = h$ gives $c_1 = \sum_{v=2}^{N} \beta_v(h) = \frac{N}{h(h+1)} = \frac{4}{N+2}$.

(c) In the same way the second sum of Lemma 2.4, with $d = h$ and $v = t+1$, gives $\sum_t (t-1)\pi_t = \frac{2N(h-1)}{h(h+1)(h+2)}$. Dividing by $c_1 = \frac{N}{h(h+1)}$ gives $\sum_t w_t(t-1) = \frac{2(h-1)}{h+2} = 2 - \frac{6}{h+2}$, and adding $\sum_t w_t = 1$ gives the first claim. For the second claim, each factor $\frac{h-i}{N-i}$ in π_t is at most $\frac{1}{2}$, so $\pi_t \le \frac{t}{N-t}2^{1-t}$. Hence $w_t = \frac{N+2}{4}\pi_t \le \frac{N+2}{2(N-t)}\, t2^{-t}$. For $t \le h$ we have $N - t \ge h$ and $\frac{N+2}{2h} = 1 + \frac{2}{N} \le 2$, so $w_t \le 2t2^{-t}$. □

So to first order the walk flips once, at some step $t+1$, and then runs as Pólya's urn from t balls of one color and one of the other. As $N \to \infty$ the final fraction of the color that started with one ball tends in law to a Beta$(1,t)$ variable, whose density at $\frac{1}{2}$ is $t2^{1-t}$, and $\sum_t t2^{1-t} = 4$ explains the constant $4/(N+2)$. Since $w_t \le 2t2^{-t}$, only an early flip counts in this first-order term.

2.2 Two-sided bounds on the center

This subsection bounds the center from both sides. The bounds give the crossing in the next subsection.

Theorem 2.6. *Let $N \ge 2$ be even.*

(a) For $0 < \varepsilon < \frac{1}{2}$, $C_N \ge \frac{4\varepsilon}{N+2}(1-2\varepsilon)$.

(b) The bound $C_N \le \frac{4\varepsilon}{N+2}\, N^{2\varepsilon}e^{5200\varepsilon}$ holds whenever $0 < \varepsilon(1+\log N) \le \frac{1}{100}$.

In particular $\log(1-2\varepsilon) \le \log C_N - \log\frac{4\varepsilon}{N+2} \le \varepsilon(2\log N + 5200)$ in the range of (b).

Part (a) also holds for $\frac{1}{2} \le \varepsilon < 1$, trivially, because its right side is not positive there.

Idea of the proof. The proof is in Appendix A. After the first flip, M at time s is Pólya's urn with αs extra balls of each color, where $\alpha = \varepsilon/(1-2\varepsilon)$ (Lemma A.1). They pull the minority fraction toward $\frac{1}{2}$. For (a) we drop them. For (b) we compare M with an urn with $\kappa(s+10)$ extra balls, where $\kappa = 2\varepsilon/(1-4\varepsilon)$. One step of M at time s multiplies the hitting probability of this urn by a factor of at most about $e^{\kappa/s}$, and the product of these factors is about $e^{\kappa H_N} \approx N^{2\varepsilon}$.

2.3 The crossing

By Theorem 2.6, $C_N \approx 4x/N^2$ when $\varepsilon = x/N$ and x is of order $\log N$. Also $E_N = \frac{1}{2}(1-x/N)^{N-1} \approx \frac{1}{2}e^{-x}$. Setting them equal gives $x + \log x \approx 2\log N - \log 8$. So let

$$\Lambda_N = 2L - \log 8, \qquad G(x) = x + \log x,$$

Table 1: Elephant crossings x_N and the root g_N of $G(g) = \Lambda_N$. These values are numerical and are not used in any proof. We computed x_N in double precision from the recursion of Lemma 2.2, by Brent's method with an absolute tolerance of 10^{-12} in x, and we found g_N with a tolerance of about 10^{-15}.

N	x_N	g_N	$x_N/\log N$
50	3.940487	4.288636	1.007
400	7.629217	7.843768	1.273
1600	10.240565	10.340051	1.388
3200	11.546834	11.610464	1.431
12800	14.158845	14.182921	1.497
51200	16.778468	16.786946	1.547

and let g_N be the root of $G(g_N) = \Lambda_N$. It exists and is unique, since G increases from $-\infty$ to ∞ on $(0, \infty)$.

Theorem 2.7. *As $N \to \infty$ over even N, the following hold.*

(a) The crossing satisfies $x_N + \log x_N = \Lambda_N + O(L^2/N)$, so $x_N = g_N + O(L^2/N)$.

(b) The crossing satisfies $x_N = 2\log N - \log\log N - \log 16 + O(\log\log N/\log N)$.

Proof. (a) *Step 1. Both sides near the crossing.* Put $F(x) = \log C_N(x/N) - \log E_N(x/N)$ for $0 < x < N$, where $C_N(\varepsilon)$ and $E_N(\varepsilon)$ are the center and the end at flip probability ε. By Proposition 2.3, F is strictly increasing and x_N is its only zero. We show that

$$|F(x) - G(x) + \Lambda_N| \le \rho_N \quad (1 \le x \le 2\Lambda_N), \qquad \text{with } \rho_N = O(L^2/N). \tag{$*$}$$

Let $1 \le x \le 2\Lambda_N$ and $\varepsilon = x/N$. Then $\varepsilon \le 4L/N$, so for large N both parts of Theorem 2.6 apply, and together they say that $\log C_N = \log \frac{4\varepsilon}{N+2} + O(\varepsilon L)$. Here $\log \frac{4\varepsilon}{N+2} = \log x + \log 4 - 2L - \log(1 + 2/N)$, and $\log(1 + 2/N) \le 2/N \le 2xL/N$ because $x \ge 1$. For the end we use $\log(1 - y) = -y + O(y^2)$ for $0 \le y \le \frac{1}{2}$ in $\log E_N = -\log 2 + (N-1)\log(1 - \frac{x}{N})$. So

$$\log C_N = \log x + \log 4 - 2L + O\Big(\frac{xL}{N}\Big), \qquad \log E_N = -\log 2 - x + O\Big(\frac{x^2}{N}\Big).$$

We subtract. Since $\log 4 + \log 2 = \log 8$, the main terms give $x + \log x - 2L + \log 8 = G(x) - \Lambda_N$, and both errors are $O(L^2/N)$ because $x \le 2\Lambda_N \le 4L$. This is $(*)$.

Keeping the constants gives an explicit ρ_N. Suppose that $400L(1+L) \le N$. Then $\varepsilon(1+\log N) \le 4L(1+L)/N \le \frac{1}{100}$, so the inequality after part (b) of Theorem 2.6 applies. With $\log(1-y) \ge -y-y^2$ for $0 \le y \le \frac{1}{2}$ and $x \le 4L$, the error term for $\log C_N$ above lies between $-(3 + 8L)/N$ and $(8L^2 + 20800L)/N$, and the one for $\log E_N$ lies between $-16L^2/N$ and $4L/N$. So $(*)$ holds with $\rho_N = (24L^2 + 20800L)/N$.

Step 2. Trap the zero. We have $G' = 1 + 1/x \ge 1$ and $G(g_N) = \Lambda_N$. So $G(x) - \Lambda_N < -\rho_N$ for $x < g_N - \rho_N$, and $G(x) - \Lambda_N > \rho_N$ for $x > g_N + \rho_N$. By $(*)$, $F(x) < 0$ for $1 \le x < g_N - \rho_N$ and $F(x) > 0$ for $g_N + \rho_N < x \le 2\Lambda_N$. Both ranges are nonempty for large N, because $\Lambda_N - \log\Lambda_N \le g_N \le \Lambda_N$ (note that $G(\Lambda_N - \log\Lambda_N) \le \Lambda_N \le G(\Lambda_N)$). Since F is increasing, its zero x_N lies between the two ranges, so $|x_N - g_N| \le \rho_N$. Then x_N lies in $[1, 2\Lambda_N]$, and $F(x_N) = 0$ in $(*)$ gives $|G(x_N) - \Lambda_N| \le \rho_N$. With the explicit ρ_N above, these two bounds hold for every even N with $L \ge 30$. Indeed $e^L \ge L^{12}/12!$ gives $24L^4 + 20800L^3 \le N$, so $400L(1 + L) \le N$ and $\rho_N \le 1/L^2$, and both ranges are nonempty because $g_N \ge \Lambda_N - \log\Lambda_N > 50$.

(b) We solve $g_N = \Lambda_N - \log g_N$ by one substitution. Since $\Lambda_N - \log\Lambda_N \le g_N \le \Lambda_N$, the ratio g_N/Λ_N is $1 + O(\log\Lambda_N/\Lambda_N)$, so $\log g_N = \log\Lambda_N + O(\log\Lambda_N/\Lambda_N)$. Also $\Lambda_N = 2\log N - \log 8$ gives $\log\Lambda_N = \log 2 + \log\log N + O(1/\log N)$. So $g_N = 2\log N - \log 8 - \log 2 - \log\log N + O(\log\log N/\log N)$, which is (b) for g_N, and (a) gives it for x_N. □

Table 1 gives crossings for six values of N of the form $50 \cdot 2^k$. The limit 2 of $x_N/\log N$ is approached slowly, because of the term $-\log\log N$.

In Online Resource 1, Proposition S1.1 proves a lower bound for C_N that matches Theorem 2.6(b) up to a factor $1 + O(\varepsilon)$, and Proposition S1.2 gives one more term of the crossing, which shows that $x_N < g_N$ for large N. Theorem S1.7 there compares x_N with the crossing value z_N of T for the persistent walk. It shows that $x_N - (2z_N - \log(2\pi))$ is $c_*/\log N$ to first order, with $c_* = \frac{1}{2}\log(2\pi) - \frac{1}{4}$.

3 The elephant walk near its crossing

We now look at the whole law P_N near the crossing. In this section and in Appendices B and C, a statement that says "Assume (H)" assumes

$$N \ge 64, \qquad 0 < \varepsilon \le \tfrac{1}{4}, \qquad x = N\varepsilon \ge 1. \tag{H}$$

Every other statement holds under its own hypotheses. Recall that $P_N(N-m) = \frac{1}{2}[f_N(m) + f_N(N-m)]$. Some statements also use odd N. There x_N is the value of x at which the two central bins are as likely as the ends (it exists and is unique by Proposition 3.25). For a mode $a^* \ge N/2$ of P_N we put $m^* = N - a^*$, and m_h is the largest mode of f_N.

3.1 Families and the first flip

For $k_0 \ge 1$ let $(M_k^{[k_0]})_{k \ge k_0}$ be the Markov chain with $M_{k_0}^{[k_0]} = 0$ and the transition probabilities $r_k(b)$ of M. It is the count of disagreeing steps for a walk whose first k_0 steps are forced to agree. So $M^{[1]}$ has the law of M. We write $Y_d = M_d^{[1]}$, and $Z_t^{(j)} = M_t^{[j-1]}$ for $j \ge 2$ and $t \ge j-1$. In a random recursive tree on $[N] = \{1, \dots, N\}$, vertex $k+1$ is joined to a uniform vertex of $[k]$, independently for $k = 1, \dots, N-1$. We write $\mathcal{T}_v$ for the subtree of v, that is, v and its descendants, and we call it the family of v.

Lemma 3.1 (tree and marks)**.** *Let $\mathcal{T}$ be the tree on $[N]$ in which the parent of $k+1$ is U_k. For $2 \le v \le N$ let $\mu_v = 1$ if step v flips the step it copies, and $\mu_v = 0$ otherwise. Then $\mathcal{T}$ is a random recursive tree, the marks μ_v are i.i.d. Bernoulli(ε) and independent of $\mathcal{T}$, and $X_v = X_1(-1)^{\sigma(v)}$, where $\sigma(v)$ is the number of marks on the path from v to the root, the root excluded. So $M_N = \#\{v : \sigma(v) \text{ odd}\}$. If the marks on $2, \dots, k_0$ are set to 0, then the number of odd vertices in $[k]$, $k \ge k_0$, is a copy of the chain $M^{[k_0]}$.*

Proof. The parent U_k of $k+1$ is uniform on $[k]$ and independent of the earlier choices, and the marks are the flip indicators. The path from $k+1$ to the root is $k+1$ followed by the path from U_k, so $\sigma(k+1) = \mu_{k+1} + \sigma(U_k)$ and, by induction on k, $X_{k+1} = X_{U_k}(-1)^{\mu_{k+1}} = X_1(-1)^{\sigma(k+1)}$. Now set $\mu_2 = \cdots = \mu_{k_0} = 0$. If b of the vertices in $[k]$ are odd, $k \ge k_0$, then $k+1$ is odd with conditional probability $(1-\varepsilon)\frac{b}{k} + \varepsilon(1 - \frac{b}{k}) = r_k(b)$, whatever else is known about $[k]$. □

So a single flip at v turns every step of its family (Figure 1). For $k \ge v$, if $\mathcal{T}_v$ contains s of the vertices in $[k]$, then $k+1$ joins $\mathcal{T}_v$ with probability s/k. This is the urn of Lemma 2.4, so $|\mathcal{T}_v|$

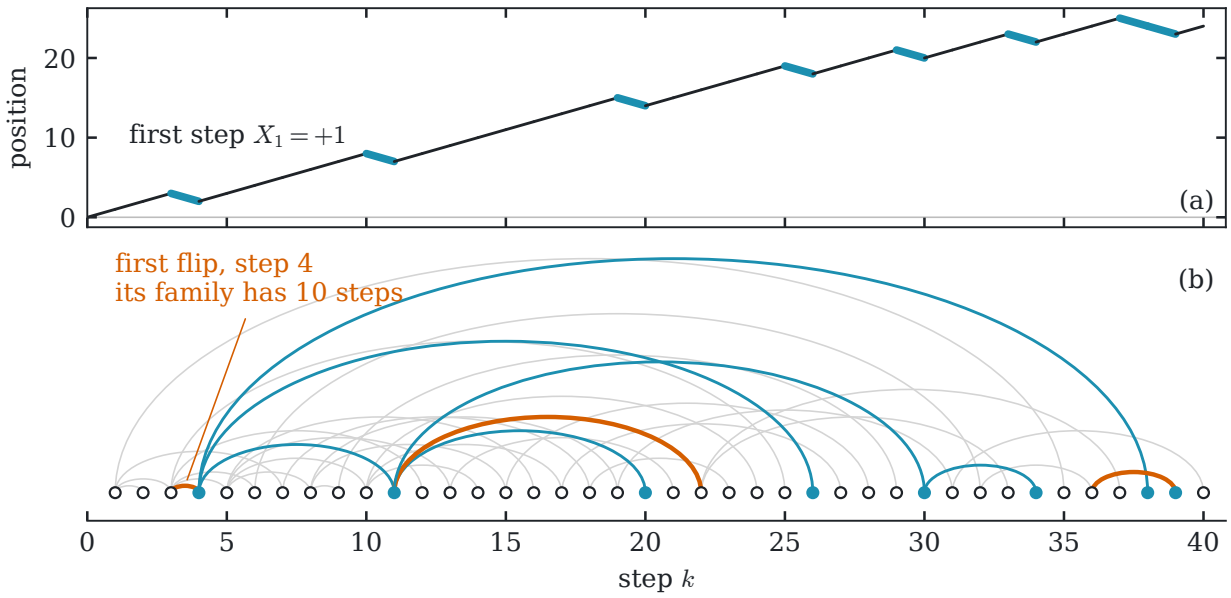


Figure 1: One elephant walk with $N = 40$ steps and $\varepsilon = 0.07$. (a) The position against the step. The steps that disagree with the first step are drawn heavier and in blue. (b) The memory tree of the same walk. Step $k+1$ copies the step at the left end of its arc, and the arcs drawn heavier are flips. A step disagrees with the first step exactly when the path from it to step 1 crosses an odd number of flips (Lemma 3.1). The first flip, at step 4, turns its family of ten steps. The flip at step 22, inside that family, turns its own family of three steps back, and the flip at step 39 turns only that step.

has the law β_v and mean N/v, and on average there are $N/(d(d+1))$ families of size d. If v is the only marked vertex, the odd vertices are those of $\mathcal{T}_v$. Two or more marks have probability $O(\varepsilon^2)$ at fixed N, and no mark gives $M_N = 0$. So at fixed N the part of $f_N(m)$ of first order in ε is exactly $\varepsilon \sum_v \beta_v(m) = x/(m(m+1))$ for $1 \le m \le N-1$, which is the formula of [19, Eq. (10)] with one cell at the start. It is also proved in Lean for the chain M (Section 4).

To go beyond first order we cut the tree at the first flip.

Lemma 3.2 (splitting)**.** *Let $\mathcal{T}$ be a random recursive tree on $[N]$, let $2 \le v \le N$ and let $S \subseteq [N]$ with $\min S = v$. Given that $\mathcal{T}_v$ has vertex set S, the restrictions of $\mathcal{T}$ to S and to $[N] \setminus S$, relabeled in increasing order, are independent random recursive trees. They are independent of the parent of v, which is uniform on $[v-1]$.*

Proof. The tree $\mathcal{T}$ is uniform over the $(N-1)!$ increasing trees on $[N]$. Its family $\mathcal{T}_v$ has vertex set S exactly when every $u \in S \setminus \{v\}$ has its parent in S and every $u \notin S$ with $u \ge 2$ has its parent outside S. So, given this event, each element of S other than v picks its parent freely among the smaller elements of S, v picks any element of $[v-1]$, and each element of $[N] \setminus S$ other than 1 picks freely among the smaller elements of $[N] \setminus S$. This is the claim. □

Lemma 3.3 (the first flip)**.** *Let $V = \min\{v \ge 2 : \mu_v = 1\}$, with $V = \infty$ and $|\mathcal{T}_V| = 0$ if there is no mark. If $V < \infty$, let $\bar{Y}$ be the number of vertices u of $\mathcal{T}_V$ with $\sigma(u)$ even, and let $\bar{Z}$ be the number of odd vertices outside $\mathcal{T}_V$. Then for $2 \le j \le N$, $1 \le d \le N - j + 1$ and integers y, z,*

$$\mathbb{P}\big(V = j,\, |\mathcal{T}_V| = d,\, \bar{Y} = y,\, \bar{Z} = z\big) = \varepsilon(1-\varepsilon)^{j-2}\beta_j(d)\,\mathbb{P}(Y_d = y)\,\mathbb{P}\big(Z^{(j)}_{N-d} = z\big).$$

In particular $\mathbb{P}(V = j,\, |\mathcal{T}_V| = d) = \varepsilon(1-\varepsilon)^{j-2}\beta_j(d)$, *and for* $m \geq 1$

$$f_N(m) = \sum_{j=2}^{N} \varepsilon(1-\varepsilon)^{j-2} \sum_{d=1}^{N-j+1} \beta_j(d)\, \mathbb{P}\big(d - Y_d + Z_{N-d}^{(j)} = m\big),$$

where Y_d *and* $Z_{N-d}^{(j)}$ *are independent.*

Proof. Marks and tree are independent, and $|\mathcal{T}_j|$ has the law β_j, which gives the law of $(V, |\mathcal{T}_V|)$. Condition on $V = j$ and on the vertex set S of $\mathcal{T}_j$, with $|S| = d$. The marks on $j+1, \ldots, N$ are still i.i.d., and by Lemma 3.2 the trees on S and on $[N] \setminus S$ are independent random recursive trees. The vertices $1, \ldots, j-1$ carry no mark, so j is odd, and $u \in S$ is even exactly when the path from u up to j, with j excluded, has an odd number of marks. So by Lemma 3.1 for the tree on S rooted at j, the count $\bar{Y}$ has the law of Y_d. Paths from outside S stay outside S, and the tree on $[N] \setminus S$ has the unmarked vertices $1, \ldots, j-1$ first. So by Lemma 3.1 the count $\bar{Z}$ has the law of $Z_{N-d}^{(j)}$. The two counts are functions of the two trees and of the marks on the two disjoint sets S and $[N] \setminus S$, so they are independent, and their joint law depends on S only through d. This gives the joint law. On $\{V = j\}$ we have $M_N = d - \bar{Y} + \bar{Z}$, and $M_N = 0$ if there is no mark. Summing over j, d and the pairs (y, z) with $d - y + z = m$ gives the formula for $f_N(m)$. □

So the first flip turns its whole family except the steps of that family that flip back, and the rest of the tree is a walk whose first $j-1$ steps agree with X_1. Only the law of each pair $(Y_d, Z_{N-d}^{(j)})$ enters the lemma. So from now on $(Y_d)_{d \geq 1}$ is a copy of the chain $M^{[1]}$, and $(Z_t^{(j)})_{t \geq j-1}$ is a copy of $M^{[j-1]}$, independent of Y and of $(V, |\mathcal{T}_V|)$.

Lemma 3.4 (unimodality given the first step [7, Section 2, proof of Theorem 1.1])**.** *The function* f_N *is unimodal.*

This is shown at the start of the proof of Theorem 1.1 of [7], for every N and every memory parameter $p = 1 - \varepsilon \in [0, 1]$, for the position $N - 2M_N$ given $X_1 = +1$. The lemma is also proved in Lean (Section 4). So f_N is nondecreasing on $\{0, \ldots, m_h\}$ and nonincreasing on $\{m_h, \ldots, N\}$. With a fair first step, P_N mixes f_N and its mirror image. When the mode of f_N is far from the center, the mixture can have two humps, one near each end.

3.2 The end and its neighbor

We first say heuristically why the end should fall below its neighbor once $x > 2$ (Figure 2(a), inset). Given $X_1 = +1$, the end needs no flip at all. Its neighbor, bin $N-1$, needs one flip that is never copied. A flip at step j is never copied with probability about j/N. Summing $\varepsilon j/N$ over j gives a factor of about $x/2$ in favor of the neighbor.

Theorem 3.5 (endpoint dip)**.** *Let* $N \geq 2$ *and* $0 < \varepsilon < 1$, *and put* $\rho_1 = P_N(N-1)/E_N$. *Then*

$$\rho_1 > \frac{x}{2(1-\varepsilon)}.$$

If moreover $N \geq 3$ *and* $\varepsilon \leq \frac{1}{2}$, *then*

$$\rho_1 \leq \frac{x(1+1/N)^2}{2-3\varepsilon} + \frac{\varepsilon}{1-\varepsilon}.$$

Hence the end is strictly below its neighbor if $x \geq 2(1-\varepsilon)$. *If* $N \geq 3$, $\varepsilon \leq \frac{1}{2}$ *and the right side of the second bound is below* 1, *the end is strictly above its neighbor.*

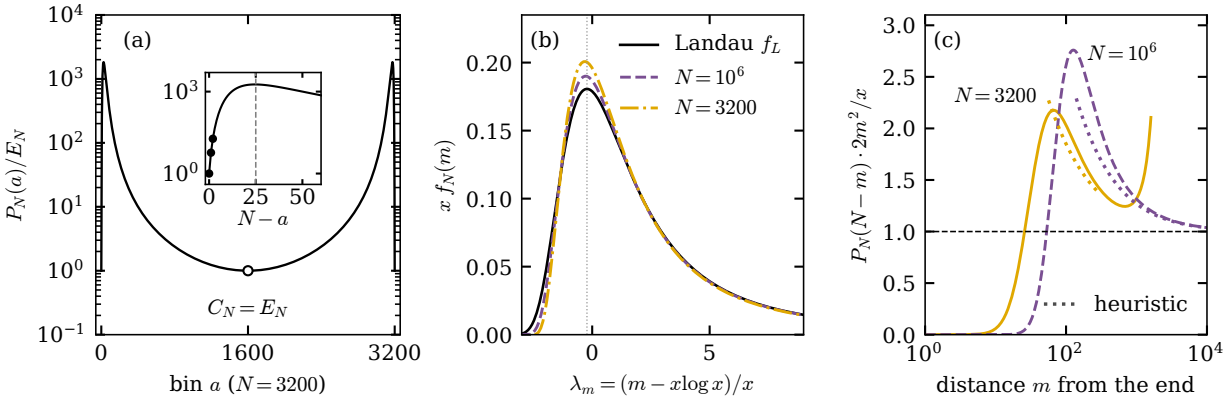


Figure 2: The elephant walk at its crossing. (a) The law P_N for $N = 3200$ at its crossing $x = 11.5468$, divided by the end E_N. The center equals the end, and the law rises from each end to a mode and falls to the center. The inset shows the last 60 bins, with dots at bins N, $N-1$ and $N-2$. The end is below its neighbor, and the modes are 25 bins from each end (dashed). (b) The law of M_N, scaled as $xf_N(m)$, against $\lambda_m = (m - x\log x)/x$, with the Landau density f_L. The dotted line is its mode λ_{L}. (c) The tail $P_N(N-m)$ divided by $x/(2m^2)$. The dashed line is the limit 1 of Theorem S2.1 of Online Resource 1, and the dotted curves are the heuristic correction $1 + x(2\log m + 2\gamma - 3)/m$ for $2x\log x \le m \le N/x$. The rise of the $N = 3200$ curve near $m = N/2$ is the mirror term $f_N(N-m)$. At $N = 10^6$ we use $x = g_N = 22.4407$.

Proof. By Lemma 2.2, $\rho_1 = \big(f_N(1) + f_N(N-1)\big)/f_N(0)$ with $f_N(0) = (1-\varepsilon)^{N-1}$. We bound the two terms in turn.

The term $f_N(1)$. On the event $M_N = 1$ the chain moves up exactly once, say from time $j-1$ to time j with $2 \le j \le N$. Before that it stays at 0 for $j-2$ steps, each with probability $1 - r_t(0) = 1 - \varepsilon$. The move up has probability ε. After it the chain stays at 1 at the times $k = j, \dots, N-1$, each with probability $1 - r_k(1) = (1-\varepsilon)(1 - c'/k)$, where $c' = (1-2\varepsilon)/(1-\varepsilon) \le 1$. Multiplying and summing over j gives

$$f_N(1) = \varepsilon(1-\varepsilon)^{N-2} \sum_{j=2}^{N} \vartheta_j, \qquad \vartheta_j = \prod_{k=j}^{N-1} \Big(1 - \frac{c'}{k}\Big).$$

For the lower bound we use $c' \le 1$. Then $\vartheta_j \ge \prod_{k=j}^{N-1}(1 - 1/k) = (j-1)/(N-1)$, and these lower bounds sum to $N/2$ over $2 \le j \le N$. So $f_N(1)/f_N(0) \ge x/(2(1-\varepsilon))$. For the upper bound let $N \ge 3$ and $\varepsilon \le \frac{1}{2}$, so that $c' \ge 0$. Then $1 - c'/k \le e^{-c'/k}$ and $\sum_{k=j}^{N-1} 1/k \ge \log(N/j)$ give $\vartheta_j \le (j/N)^{c'}$. As $(t/N)^{c'}$ is nondecreasing in t, we can compare the sum with an integral, namely

$$\sum_{j=2}^{N} \vartheta_j \le \int_2^{N+1} \Big(\frac{t}{N}\Big)^{c'} dt \le \frac{N(1+1/N)^{c'+1}}{c'+1} \le \frac{N(1+1/N)^2(1-\varepsilon)}{2-3\varepsilon},$$

using $c' \le 1$ and $1/(c'+1) = (1-\varepsilon)/(2-3\varepsilon)$. So $f_N(1)/f_N(0) \le x(1+1/N)^2/(2-3\varepsilon)$.

The term $f_N(N-1)$. The event $M_N = N-1$ needs an up move at every time. The first has probability $r_1(0) = \varepsilon$, and the one at time $k \ge 2$ has probability $r_k(k-1) = 1 - \varepsilon - (1-2\varepsilon)/k$. This lies strictly between 0 and 1, as every $r_k(b)$ with $0 < b < k$ does, and it lies in $[\frac{1}{2}, 1-\varepsilon]$ when $\varepsilon \le \frac{1}{2}$. So $f_N(N-1) > 0$, and $f_N(N-1) \le \varepsilon(1-\varepsilon)^{N-2}$ when $\varepsilon \le \frac{1}{2}$. This makes the lower bound

strict and gives the term $\varepsilon/(1-\varepsilon)$ in the upper bound. (For $N=2$ the bins 1 and $N-1$ coincide, and the argument is the same.) □

Corollary 3.6 (the dip at the crossing)**.** *Let $N \geq 2$ be even and $0 < \varepsilon < 1$, and suppose that $x \geq 2(1-\varepsilon)$ and $C_N \leq E_N$. Then $C_N \leq E_N < P_N(N-1)$, and P_N is not unimodal. In particular, if $x_N \geq 2(1-\varepsilon_N)$, then at the crossing $E_N = C_N < P_N(N-1)$, and P_N is not unimodal.*

Proof. Theorem 3.5 gives $P_N(N-1) > E_N \geq C_N$. Suppose that P_N is nondecreasing on $\{0,\dots,a_0\}$ and nonincreasing on $\{a_0,\dots,N\}$. It is symmetric about h, so we may replace a_0 by $N-a_0$ and assume $a_0 \leq h$. Then $P_N(a) \leq C_N$ for every $a \geq h$, including $a = N-1$, which is a contradiction. □

By Proposition 2.3, $C_N \leq E_N$ holds exactly when $\varepsilon \leq \varepsilon_N$, and $x \geq 2(1-\varepsilon)$ says that $\varepsilon \geq 2/(N+2)$. So the corollary covers the ε with $2/(N+2) \leq \varepsilon \leq \varepsilon_N$. In particular the condition $x_N \geq 2(1-\varepsilon_N)$ says that $\varepsilon_N \geq 2/(N+2)$. By Proposition 2.3 it holds exactly when $C_N \leq E_N$ at $\varepsilon = 2/(N+2)$. We now show that this is so for every even $N \geq 8$.

Proposition 3.7 (the hypothesis holds from $N=8$ on, computer-assisted)**.** *For every even $N \geq 8$ we have $C_N < E_N$ at $\varepsilon = 2/(N+2)$, and hence $x_N > 2(1-\varepsilon_N)$. So for every even $N \geq 8$, at the crossing $E_N = C_N < P_N(N-1)$, and P_N is not unimodal. For $N = 2$, 4 and 6 the condition $x_N \geq 2(1-\varepsilon_N)$ fails, and no ε meets the hypotheses of Corollary 3.6.*

Proof. The range $N \geq 1688$. Take $\varepsilon = 2/N$. Then $\varepsilon(1+\log N) \leq \frac{1}{100}$, so Theorem 2.6(b) gives $C_N \leq \frac{8}{N(N+2)} N^{4/N} e^{10400/N}$. The right side decreases in N and is below $1.4 \cdot 10^{-3}$ at $N = 1688$. Since $\log(1-y) \geq -y - y^2$ for $0 \leq y \leq \frac{1}{2}$, we also have $E_N = \frac{1}{2}(1-\frac{2}{N})^{N-1} \geq \frac{1}{2} e^{-2-2/N} > 0.06$. So $C_N < E_N$ at $\varepsilon = 2/N$, and Proposition 2.3 gives $\varepsilon_N > 2/N$. Hence $C_N < E_N$ at $\varepsilon = 2/(N+2)$ as well.

The range $8 \leq N < 1688$. For $N = 8$ the ratio C_N/E_N at $\varepsilon = 2/(N+2)$ is exactly $\frac{67903}{71680} < 1$. For even $10 \leq N \leq 2000$ the script `certify_center.py` encloses ε_N in ball arithmetic as in the proof of Proposition 3.24, and it checks by an exact rational comparison that the lower end of the enclosure lies above $2/(N+2)$. So $\varepsilon_N > 2/(N+2)$, and Proposition 2.3 gives $C_N < E_N$ at $\varepsilon = 2/(N+2)$. The ratio of the lower end to $2/(N+2)$ is at least 1.107, with its minimum at $N = 10$.

The three smallest N. At $\varepsilon = 2/(N+2)$ the ratio C_N/E_N is exactly 2, $\frac{5}{3}$ and $\frac{508}{405}$ for $N = 2$, 4 and 6, so $\varepsilon_N < 2/(N+2)$ there. These ratios and the one for $N = 8$ are computed in exact rational arithmetic by `certify_elephant.py`. The last claim of the proposition about $N \geq 8$ is Corollary 3.6. □

3.3 The bulk

The steps that disagree with X_1 lie in the flipped families. Recall the compound Poisson law CP_N of Section 1.2. On average $x/(d(d+1))$ flipped vertices have a family of size d. If no flipped step has a flipped descendant, which is likely when $x^2 \log N/N$ is small, then M_N is the total size of the flipped families, and this is close to the compound Poisson sum.

The law CP_N and its Landau limit are known (Section 1.3). What the two theorems below add is the truncation at $d = N-1$, a rate with explicit constants in both theorems, and the transfer to the elephant walk in sup norm. Numerical values of f_L and of its mode are standard (see Kölbig and Schorr [26]). What Lemma 3.10 adds is a certified enclosure.

Theorem 3.8 (compound Poisson bulk). *For $N \geq 1$ and $0 < \varepsilon < 1$,*

$$\sup_{m \geq 0} \bigl| f_N(m) - \mathrm{CP}_N(m) \bigr| \leq \delta_\Sigma := \varepsilon^2 (N H_N - 2N + 1) + 2\varepsilon^2 (N-1) + 4\varepsilon^2 \sum_{k=0}^{N-2} (H_k^2 + H_k).$$

Also $\delta_\Sigma \leq \delta_B := \frac{x^2 \log N}{N} + \frac{4x^2}{N} e^{4x^2/N} + \frac{4x^2 (H_N^2 + H_N)}{N}$.

Bin by bin, the law of the number of disagreeing steps is within δ_Σ of the compound Poisson law. Bounding each H_k by H_N gives $\delta_\Sigma \leq \frac{x^2}{N}(\log N + 2 + 4H_N^2 + 4H_N)$, so $\delta_\Sigma = O(x^2 \log^2 N / N)$.

Idea of the proof. The proof is in Appendix C. Let Z_+ be the total size of the flipped families. Then $M_N = Z_+$ unless some flipped step has a flipped descendant, and this has probability at most $x^2 \log N / N$. Given the tree, Z_+ is a sum of independent terms, so its characteristic function is a product, and the product is close to $e^{\varepsilon F}$ with $F = \sum_v (e^{i\theta |\mathcal{T}_v|} - 1)$. The mean of εF is exactly the logarithm of the characteristic function of CP_N. So it remains to show that F is close to its mean. For this we use the Efron–Stein inequality [27]. Changing the parent of one vertex changes the family sizes only along two paths to the root, and these paths have length of order $\log N$.

The families of size up to about x add up to nearly $x \log x$, and the few families of size of order x give fluctuations of order x. So we center M_N at $x \log x$ and divide by x, which gives the coordinate λ_m and the Landau density f_L of Section 1.2. It is a stable density with index one. We show in Appendix C that e^B is the characteristic function of a probability law of class L, so that f_L is a unimodal probability density by [28].

Theorem 3.9 (Landau limit). *(a) Let $x \geq 1$ and $N \geq 4x$. For every integer m, with $\mathrm{CP}_N(m) = 0$ for $m < 0$,*

$$\bigl| x\, \mathrm{CP}_N(m) - f_L(\lambda_m) \bigr| \leq E_0 := \frac{889 + 165 \log x}{x} + \frac{6.6\, x}{N} \leq 889 \Bigl(\frac{1 + \log x}{x} + \frac{x}{N} \Bigr).$$

(b) Let $0 < \varepsilon \leq \frac{1}{4}$ and $x \geq 1$. For every integer $m \geq 0$,

$$\bigl| x f_N(m) - f_L(\lambda_m) \bigr| \leq E_0 + x\delta_\Sigma \leq 889 \Bigl(\frac{1 + \log x}{x} + \frac{x}{N} \Bigr) + x\delta_B.$$

(c) Let $N_n \geq 1$ and $0 < \varepsilon_n < 1$ for $n \geq 1$, and put $x_n = N_n \varepsilon_n$. If $x_n \to \infty$ and $x_n^3 \log^2 N_n / N_n \to 0$, then $(M_{N_n} - x_n \log x_n)/x_n$ converges in law to the law with density f_L.

Near the crossing the number of disagreeing steps is about $x \log x$, with fluctuations of order x that follow the Landau law, bin by bin (Figure 2(b)). Both conditions of (c) hold at the crossing, by Theorem 2.7.

Idea of the proof. The proof is in Appendix C. If we allow every jump size $d \geq 1$, the characteristic function of the compound Poisson law is $e^{x\chi(e^{i\theta})}$ with $\chi(s) = (1-s)\log(1-s)/s$, and the jumps $d \geq N$ change it little. For small θ we have $\chi(e^{i\theta}) = -i\theta \log(-i\theta) + O(\theta^2 |\log|\theta||)$. With $\theta = t/x$ the exponent becomes $B(t) + it \log x$ plus an error of order $t^2 \log x / x$. The term $it \log x$ is the centering at $x \log x$. Both characteristic functions decay like $e^{-c|t|}$, so Fourier inversion turns this into a bound for each bin, and keeping the constants gives 889 and 165. Part (b) then follows from Theorem 3.8.

To locate the modes we need to know that f_L is curved at its maximum.

Lemma 3.10 (the mode of the Landau density, computer-assisted). *(a) The density f_L has exactly one mode λ_{L}, and $-0.22278299 < \lambda_{\mathrm{L}} < -0.22278297$. It is nondecreasing on $(-\infty, \lambda_{\mathrm{L}}]$ and nonincreasing on $[\lambda_{\mathrm{L}}, \infty)$.*

(b) The derivative vanishes at the mode, $f_L'(\lambda_{\mathrm{L}}) = 0$, and $-0.0792 \le f_L''(\lambda) \le -0.0786$ for $-0.2229 \le \lambda \le -0.2227$.

(c) For every real λ, $f_L(\lambda_{\mathrm{L}}) - f_L(\lambda) \ge \kappa_L \min\{1, (\lambda - \lambda_{\mathrm{L}})^2\}$ with $\kappa_L = 2.6 \cdot 10^{-10}$.

The proof is in Appendix C.3, and it is computer-assisted. Lean proves the lemma as well, with the unimodality of f_L that [28] gives as its only input (Section 4), so the computation in ball arithmetic is an independent check.

Corollary 3.11 (where the modes are). *(a) Assume (H). Let κ_L be as in Lemma 3.10(c), let $E_1 = 889\big(\frac{1+\log x}{x} + \frac{x}{N}\big) + x\delta_B$ be the bound of Theorem 3.9(b), and put*

$$E' = E_1 + \frac{16x^2 H_N}{N^2} + \frac{\|f_L''\|_\infty}{8x^2}.$$

If $E' < \kappa_L/2$ and $m_h \le N/4$, then every mode $a^* \ge N/2$ of P_N satisfies $|m^* - x\log x - \lambda_{\mathrm{L}} x| \le x\sqrt{2E'/\kappa_L}$, and so does every mode of f_N.

(b) There are K and N_2 such that the following holds for every $N \ge N_2$, even or odd, and every ε with $\log N \le x \le 2\log N$. Every mode $a^* \ge N/2$ of P_N has

$$\big|m^* - x\log x - \lambda_{\mathrm{L}} x\big| \le K\sqrt{x\log x},$$

and so has every mode of f_N in place of m^*. In particular this holds at the crossing, with $x = x_N$, for every large even N (Theorem 2.7(b)).

In (a) every constant is explicit. (Here $\|f_L''\|_\infty \le 16/\pi^4$, since $|e^{B(t)}| = e^{-\pi|t|/2}$.) We do not compute K and N_2 in (b).

So each hump of the law at the crossing sits about $x\log x - 0.2228\,x$ bins from its end. The proof is in Appendix C.4. It compares f_N at a mode with f_N at the integer nearest to $x\log x + \lambda_{\mathrm{L}} x$, and uses Theorem 3.9(b) and Lemma 3.10(c).

Remark 3.12 (how good the bulk approximation is). The bounds of this subsection are far from sharp at the sizes we can compute. At $N = 10^6$ and $x = 22.4407$ the bound δ_B is still about 0.46, but there the computed law has $|f_N(m)/\mathrm{CP}_N(m) - 1| \le 3.6 \cdot 10^{-4}$ for $1 \le m \le 10^4$. At every tested crossing m^* equals the mode of CP_N. The proof of Corollary 3.11(b) needs the bound of Theorem 3.9(b) to be below $\kappa_L/2$, where $\kappa_L = 2.6 \cdot 10^{-10}$ is the constant of Lemma 3.10(c). With the constant 889 this needs $x > 2 \cdot 10^{14}$, and numerically the best κ_L is about 0.026. These numbers are computed in double precision and are not used in any proof.

3.4 The tail

Beyond the humps the law falls like $x/(2m^2)$. Theorem S2.1 of Online Resource 1 proves that $P_N(N-m) = \frac{x}{2m^2}(1 + o(1))$ for even N with $x \ge 1$ and $x\log^2 N/N \to 0$, uniformly for $\omega_N x \log^2(x+1) \le m \le \delta_N' N$, for every $\omega_N \to \infty$ and every $\delta_N' \to 0$.

At $N = 10^6$, $x = 22.4407$ and $m = 10^4$ the computed ratio $P_N(N-m)/(x/(2m^2))$ is 1.03777. Heuristically, at moderate m the law CP_N suggests $f_N(m)\,m(m+1)/x \approx 1 + x(2\log m + 2\gamma - 3)/m$, which we do not prove. This factor is still about 2 near $m = 70$ when $N = 3200$ (Figure 2(c)).

3.5 Convexity between the humps

Definition 3.13 (convex between the humps)**.** Let $N \geq 5$. The law at the crossing is *convex between the humps* if, for $x = x_N$ and every mode $a^* \geq N/2$ of P_N with $m^* = N - a^*$, the second difference $P_N(a-1) - 2P_N(a) + P_N(a+1)$ is positive for $2m^* + 1 \leq a \leq N - 2m^* - 1$.

With the symmetry of the law, this makes P_N strictly convex on $[2m^*, N - 2m^*]$, so h is its unique minimizer there (the two central bins for odd N). The constants of the large-N results below are not computed, so the following is open.

Conjecture 3.14 (convexity between the humps)**.** *For every $N > 2000$ the law at the crossing is convex between the humps.*

In double precision the law at the crossing is also convex between the humps for $N = 3200$, 6400, 12800 and 25600. The definition leaves out the two endpoints $a = 2m^*$ and $a = N - 2m^*$, because there the second difference is not positive for some $N \leq 51$. Heuristically, between the humps $P_N(a)$ is close to $\frac{x}{2}\big[\frac{1}{a(a+1)} + \frac{1}{(N-a)(N-a+1)}\big]$, which is strictly convex in a. We also leave open the tail for m between about $x \log x$ and $x \log^2 x$, below the range of Theorem S2.1 of Online Resource 1.

Throughout this subsection $0 < \varepsilon < \frac{1}{2}$ and $c = 1 - 2\varepsilon$, so that $r_t(b) = \varepsilon + cb/t$. For $t \geq 1$ and every integer a we write $P_t(a) = \mathbb{P}(A_t = a)$, which is 0 unless $0 \leq a \leq t$, and

$$D_t(a) = P_t(a+1) - 2P_t(a) + P_t(a-1).$$

We also put $s_t = D_t(1) = P_t(0) - 2P_t(1) + P_t(2)$ for $t \geq 2$.

Lemma 3.15 (recurrence for the second difference)**.** *For every $t \geq 1$ and every integer a,*

$$P_{t+1}(a) = \big(1 - r_t(a)\big)P_t(a) + r_t(a-1)\,P_t(a-1), \tag{1}$$
$$D_{t+1}(a) = \big(1 - r_t(a+1)\big)D_t(a) + r_t(a-2)\,D_t(a-1). \tag{2}$$

Also $P_t(a) = P_t(t-a)$ and $D_t(a) = D_t(t-a)$. The same two recurrences hold with $f_t(m)$ in place of $P_t(a)$.

Proof. Given $A_t = a$, the copied step is $+1$ with probability a/t, so step $t+1$ is $+1$ with probability $(1-\varepsilon)\frac{a}{t} + \varepsilon(1 - \frac{a}{t}) = r_t(a)$. This gives (1) for $0 \leq a \leq t+1$, where at $a = 0$ and at $a = t+1$ the formula has one extra term, namely $r_t(-1)P_t(-1)$ or $(1 - r_t(t+1))P_t(t+1)$, and this term is 0 because $P_t(-1) = P_t(t+1) = 0$. For other a every term vanishes. The symmetry of P_t is Lemma 2.2, and it gives the symmetry of D_t. The chain M of Lemma 2.2 has the same transition probabilities, so (1) holds for f_t as well.

For (2) put $\varsigma = c/t$, so that $r_t(b+1) = r_t(b) + \varsigma$. We insert (1) at $a+1$, a and $a-1$ into the definition of $D_{t+1}(a)$ and collect the coefficients of $P_t(a+1)$, $P_t(a)$, $P_t(a-1)$ and $P_t(a-2)$. They are

$$1 - r_t(a+1), \qquad 3r_t(a) - 2, \qquad 1 - 3r_t(a-1), \qquad r_t(a-2).$$

The right side of (2) has the coefficients $1-r_t(a+1)$, $-2+2r_t(a+1)+r_t(a-2)$, $1-r_t(a+1)-2r_t(a-2)$ and $r_t(a-2)$. The second ones agree because $2r_t(a+1) + r_t(a-2) = 3r_t(a)$, and the third ones agree because $r_t(a+1) + 2r_t(a-2) = 3r_t(a-1)$. □

Trinas and Valle [8, (2.2)] write (1) for the mass function of the position, which is the forward equation of the counting chain of Lemma 2.2, and they use it for a local limit theorem in the

superdiffusive regime. In [8, (4.10)] they write the analogue of (2) for differences of higher order, and they use it at a fixed memory parameter in a certified study of log-concavity. We use (2) for signs. The coefficients in (2) are positive when $2 \le a \le t-1$. So the second difference moves like a mass that is partly killed, and its sign can change only through what enters at the two edges. The next lemma is the elementary form of the variation diminishing property that we need.

For a finite list z of real numbers let $\mathrm{sp}(z)$ be its sign pattern. We delete the zeros of z, replace each entry by its sign, and merge equal neighbors. So $\mathrm{sp}(z)$ is a list of alternating signs. For two such lists we write $p \preceq q$ if p is a subsequence of q. We put $\Pi_5 = (+,-,+,-,+)$ and $\Pi_3 = (+,-,+)$.

Lemma 3.16 (one step)**.** *Let $\zeta = (\zeta_1, \dots, \zeta_n)$ be real, and let $\eta_i = A_i\zeta_i + B_i\zeta_{i+1}$ for $1 \le i \le n-1$ with $A_i \ge 0$ and $B_i \ge 0$. Let $w = (\zeta_1, \eta_1, \zeta_2, \eta_2, \dots, \eta_{n-1}, \zeta_n)$. Then $\mathrm{sp}(w) = \mathrm{sp}(\zeta)$ and $\mathrm{sp}(\eta) \preceq \mathrm{sp}(\zeta)$.*

We prove this in Online Resource 1, Section S5.A.

Lemma 3.17 (the sequence next to the end)**.** *For every $t_1 \ge 2$ we have $\mathrm{sp}(s_2, s_3, \dots, s_{t_1}) \preceq \Pi_3$. Also, for every $0 \le \varepsilon \le 1$, the numbers s_3 and s_4 do not both vanish.*

We prove this in Online Resource 1, Section S5.B.

Theorem 3.18 (at most five blocks)**.** *Let $N \ge 3$ and $0 < \varepsilon < \frac{1}{2}$. Then*

$$\mathrm{sp}\big(D_N(1), D_N(2), \dots, D_N(N-1)\big) \preceq (+,-,+,-,+).$$

So the second difference of P_N changes sign at most four times on $\{1, \dots, N-1\}$. The same holds for the second difference of f_N, and for f_N it holds for $N = 2$ as well.

We prove this in Online Resource 1, Section S5.C.

The next theorem is the step that turns one sign into a whole convex stretch. Its idea is short. A sign change from negative to positive at $a_0 < a_1$, together with its mirror image, gives the signs $-,+,+,-$ at $a_0 < a_1 < N - a_1 < N - a_0$. A negative second difference in between would add a fifth alternating sign, which Theorem 3.18 forbids. A zero in between is subtler. We follow it back in time through (2), whose coefficients are positive, so a zero has two zero parents unless its parents have opposite signs, and opposite signs would again give five alternating signs. Going back to $t = 5$ forces $s_3 = s_4 = 0$, which Lemma 3.17 rules out.

Theorem 3.19 (no holes)**.** *Let $N \ge 5$ and $0 < \varepsilon < \frac{1}{2}$. Let $1 \le a_0 < a_1 \le N/2$ be integers with $D_N(a_0) < 0 < D_N(a_1)$. Then $D_N(a) > 0$ for every $a_1 \le a \le N - a_1$.*

We prove this in Online Resource 1, Section S5.D.

Corollary 3.20 (one inequality is enough)**.** *Let $N \ge 8$ be even and $x = x_N$, or let $N \ge 5$ and $0 < \varepsilon < \frac{1}{2}$ be such that $P_N(0) < P_N(1)$. Let a^* be any mode of P_N and $m^* = N - a^*$. If $D_N(a_1) > 0$ for some integer a_1 with $m^* < a_1 \le 2m^* + 1$ and $a_1 \le N/2$, then $D_N(a) > 0$ for every $2m^* + 1 \le a \le N - 2m^* - 1$. In particular P_N is strictly convex on $[2m^*, N - 2m^*]$ as soon as $D_N(2m^* + 1) > 0$.*

Proof. At the crossing with $N \ge 8$ even, $P_N(0) = E_N < P_N(N-1) = P_N(1)$ by Proposition 3.7. Let a_0 be the smallest maximizer of P_N. Then $1 \le a_0 \le m^*$, because $P_N(0) < P_N(1)$ and $P_N(m^*) = P_N(a^*)$ is the maximum. Also $P_N(a_0 - 1) < P_N(a_0) \ge P_N(a_0 + 1)$, so $D_N(a_0) < 0$. Now Theorem 3.19 applies to $a_0 < a_1$. □

The condition $a_1 \le N/2$ costs nothing at $a_1 = 2m^* + 1$, because $2m^* + 1 \le N/2$ whenever the range $2m^* + 1 \le a \le N - 2m^* - 1$ is not empty. If $a^* < N/2$, then $m^* > N/2$, and no a_1 meets the conditions.

Theorem 3.21 (convexity between the humps for large N)**.** *There is N_1 such that the following holds for every $N \ge N_1$, even or odd, and every ε with $\log N \le x \le 2\log N$. For every mode $a^* \ge N/2$ of P_N with $m^* = N - a^*$ we have $4m^* + 4 \le N$ and*

$$P_N(a-1) - 2P_N(a) + P_N(a+1) > 0 \qquad \text{for } 2m^* + 1 \le a \le N - 2m^* - 1.$$

In particular, after enlarging N_1, the law at the crossing is convex between the humps for every even $N \ge N_1$. We do not compute the threshold N_1 (Remark 3.27).

Idea of the proof. By Corollary 3.20 it is enough to find one point of strict convexity between m^* and $2m^* + 1$. If there were none, P_N would be concave on $[m^*, 2m^* + 2]$, and then its value halfway would be at least half of its maximum. The Landau limit shows that the value halfway is much smaller.

Proof. Let N be large, and let $\log N \le x \le 2\log N$. Then $\varepsilon \le 2\log N/N$, so (H) holds and $\varepsilon < \frac{1}{2}$. Also $(1+\log x)/x \le (1+\log\log N)/\log N$, $x/N \le 2\log N/N$ and $x\delta_B = O(x^3 \log^2 N/N) = O(\log^5 N/N)$. So by Theorem 3.9(b) there are numbers $\Theta_N \to 0$, which depend on N alone, such that for every x in this range

$$\bigl|x f_N(m) - f_L(\lambda_m)\bigr| \le \Theta_N \qquad \text{for every integer } m \ge 0. \tag{3}$$

The density f_L is continuous, because it is the Fourier transform of an integrable function. It is unimodal with mode λ_{L} (Lemma 3.10), so it is nonincreasing on $[\lambda_{\mathrm{L}}, \infty)$, and it is integrable. So $f_L(\lambda) \to 0$ as $\lambda \to \infty$. We write $o(1)$ for a quantity that is bounded in absolute value by a function of N alone that tends to 0. So every bound below holds uniformly in x.

Step 1. The mirror term. Let $0 \le m \le N/2$. Then $\lambda_{N-m} \ge \frac{N}{2x} - \log x \ge \frac{N}{4\log N} - \log(2\log N)$, which tends to ∞. So (3) gives $x f_N(N-m) \le f_L(\lambda_{N-m}) + \Theta_N = o(1)$. Since $P_N(m) = P_N(N-m) = \frac{1}{2}[f_N(m) + f_N(N-m)]$, we get

$$2xP_N(m) = f_L(\lambda_m) + o(1) \qquad \text{uniformly for } 0 \le m \le N/2.$$

Step 2. The mode. Let m_0 be the integer part of $x\log x + \lambda_{\mathrm{L}} x$. Then $0 \le m_0 \le N/2$ and $|\lambda_{m_0} - \lambda_{\mathrm{L}}| \le 1/x$, so Step 1 and the continuity of f_L give $2xP_N(m_0) = f_L(\lambda_{\mathrm{L}}) + o(1)$. Now $P_N(m^*) \ge P_N(m_0)$ and $m^* \le N/2$, so Step 1 at m^* gives $f_L(\lambda_{m^*}) \ge f_L(\lambda_{\mathrm{L}}) - o(1)$. By Lemma 3.10(c) this forces $|\lambda_{m^*} - \lambda_{\mathrm{L}}| \le 1$ for large N. Hence

$$x\log x + (\lambda_{\mathrm{L}} - 1)x \le m^* \le x\log x + (\lambda_{\mathrm{L}} + 1)x, \qquad 2xP_N(m^*) \ge f_L(\lambda_{\mathrm{L}}) - o(1).$$

In particular $m^* \to \infty$ and $2m^* + 2 \le N/2$ for large N.

Step 3. Halfway. Let $v = m^* + \lfloor m^*/2 \rfloor$. Then $v \ge \frac{3}{2}m^* - 1$, so by Step 2

$$\lambda_v \ge \tfrac{1}{2}\log x + \tfrac{3}{2}(\lambda_{\mathrm{L}} - 1) - \tfrac{1}{x} \ge \tfrac{1}{2}\log\log N + \tfrac{3}{2}(\lambda_{\mathrm{L}} - 1) - 1,$$

which tends to ∞. Also $v \le N/2$. So Step 1 gives $2xP_N(v) = f_L(\lambda_v) + o(1) = o(1)$. Since $f_L(\lambda_{\mathrm{L}}) > 0$, Step 2 shows that $P_N(v) < \frac{1}{2}P_N(m^*)$ for large N.

Step 4. A point of convexity. Suppose that $D_N(a) \le 0$ for every $m^* < a \le 2m^* + 1$. Then P_N is concave on the integers of $[m^*, 2m^* + 2]$. With $u = m^*$ and $w = 2m^* + 2$ this gives

$$P_N(v) \ge \frac{w-v}{w-u} P_N(u) + \frac{v-u}{w-u} P_N(w) \ge \frac{w-v}{w-u} P_N(m^*) \ge \tfrac{1}{2} P_N(m^*),$$

because $w - v \ge \frac{1}{2}(m^* + 2) = \frac{1}{2}(w - u)$. This contradicts Step 3. So $D_N(a_1) > 0$ for some $m^* < a_1 \le 2m^* + 1$, and $a_1 \le N/2$ by Step 2. By Theorem 3.5, $P_N(1) = P_N(N-1) > \frac{x}{2} E_N > P_N(0)$, since $x \ge \log N > 2$. As $\varepsilon < \frac{1}{2}$, the second case of Corollary 3.20 applies and gives the claim. Finally, Theorem 2.7(b) gives $\log N \le x_N \le 2 \log N$ for every large even N, which is the last claim. □

Lemma 3.22 (the center from convexity)**.** *Let $N \ge 8$ be even and $x = x_N$. Let $a^* \ge N/2$ be a mode of P_N and $m^* = N - a^*$. Suppose that $2m^* + 1 \le N/2$ and that $D_N(a) > 0$ for every $2m^* + 1 \le a \le N - 2m^* - 1$. Then $P_N(a) > C_N$ for every $1 \le a \le N - 1$ with $a \ne h$.*

Idea of the proof. Between the humps the law is strictly convex and symmetric, so the center is its only minimum there. Outside, a bin as low as the center would be a second valley. A valley needs a point of convexity with points of concavity on both sides, and with the mirror image this gives more changes of sign of the second difference than Theorem 3.18 allows.

Proof. Write $b = 2m^*$, so that $b + 1 \le h$, and put $\delta(a) = P_N(a+1) - P_N(a)$.

Between the humps. Since $D_N(a) = \delta(a) - \delta(a-1) > 0$ for $b + 1 \le a \le N - b - 1$, the differences $\delta(a)$ are strictly increasing for $b \le a \le N - b - 1$. By symmetry $\delta(h-1) = -\delta(h)$, and $\delta(h-1) < \delta(h)$ because $b \le h - 1$. So $\delta(h-1) < 0 < \delta(h)$. Hence P_N is strictly decreasing on $\{b, \dots, h\}$ and strictly increasing on $\{h, \dots, N - b\}$, and $P_N(a) > C_N$ for every $b \le a \le N - b$ with $a \ne h$. In particular $P_N(b) > C_N$.

Near the ends. By symmetry it is enough to treat $1 \le a \le b - 1$. Suppose that $P_N(a) \le C_N$ for some such a, and let k be the smallest index in $\{1, \dots, b\}$ at which P_N takes its least value on this set. By Proposition 3.7, $P_N(1) > P_N(0) = E_N = C_N$, and $P_N(b) > C_N$. So $2 \le k \le b - 1$, and $P_N(k-1) > P_N(k) \le P_N(k+1)$, which gives $D_N(k) > 0$. Next let a' be the smallest index at which P_N takes its largest value on $\{0, \dots, k\}$. This value is at least $P_N(1)$, which exceeds both $P_N(0)$ and $P_N(k)$. So $1 \le a' \le k - 1$ and $P_N(a'-1) < P_N(a') \ge P_N(a'+1)$, which gives $D_N(a') < 0$. In the same way let a'' be the largest index at which P_N takes its largest value on $\{k, \dots, h\}$. This value is at least $P_N(b)$, which exceeds both $P_N(k)$ and $P_N(h) = C_N$. So $k + 1 \le a'' \le h - 1$ and $P_N(a''-1) \le P_N(a'') > P_N(a''+1)$, which gives $D_N(a'') < 0$. Finally $D_N(h) > 0$ by hypothesis.

So D_N has the signs $-, +, -, +$ at $a' < k < a'' < h$. By the symmetry $D_N(a) = D_N(N-a)$ it has the signs $-, +, -$ at $N - a'' < N - k < N - a'$. Hence the sign pattern of $(D_N(1), \dots, D_N(N-1))$ has a subsequence of seven alternating signs. This contradicts Theorem 3.18, which allows at most five. □

Corollary 3.23 (the center is the unique interior minimum)**.** *For every large even N, at the crossing, $P_N(a) > C_N$ for every $1 \le a \le N - 1$ with $a \ne h$. We do not compute the threshold for N.*

Proof. Let N be large and even, and let $a^* \ge N/2$ be a mode of P_N with $m^* = N - a^*$. By Corollary 3.11(b), $m^* = O(\log N \log\log N)$, so $2m^* + 1 \le N/2$ for large N. By Theorem 3.21, $D_N(a) > 0$ for $2m^* + 1 \le a \le N - 2m^* - 1$. So Lemma 3.22 applies. □

Proposition 3.24 (small N, computer-assisted)**.** *For every $5 \le N \le N_c = 2000$, even or odd, the law at the crossing is convex between the humps.*

Proof. For $10 \le N \le 2000$, the certified computation described in Section 4 brackets ε_N and encloses P_N throughout that bracket. It lists every possible mode and checks $D_N(a) > 0$ on each required range. When the range is nonempty, it also checks $D_N(a_0) < 0$ at some $1 \le a_0 \le 2m^*$ and $D_N(2m^* + 1) > 0$. Theorem 3.19 then gives a second check of the conclusion.

For $5 \le N \le 9$ the script is not run, and the check is done in Lean (Section 4) by a computation in exact integer arithmetic with outward rounding, whose soundness Lean proves. Two rationals found by bisection in exact rational arithmetic bracket ε_N. Lean proves this by Proposition 2.3 from enclosures of $P_N(\lceil N/2 \rceil)$ and E_N at the two rationals. Then Lean encloses P_N for every ε between them at once. It checks that the upper rational is below $\frac{1}{2}$, that $P_N(0) < P_N(1)$, and that every index $a^* \ge N/2$ that can be a mode either has an empty range $2m^* + 1 \le a \le N - 2m^* - 1$ or has $2m^* + 1 \le N/2$ and $D_N(2m^* + 1) > 0$. By Corollary 3.20, with $a_1 = 2m^* + 1$, this gives the claim. At $N = 5$ the only index that can be a mode is $a^* = 4$, so the range is empty and the claim holds trivially. □

Proposition 3.25 (odd N)**.** *Let $N \ge 3$ be odd, and write $\widetilde{C}_N = P_N(\frac{N-1}{2}) = P_N(\frac{N+1}{2})$ for the two central bins. The ratio $\widetilde{C}_N / E_N$ is strictly increasing in ε, and it equals 1 at exactly one $\varepsilon_N \in (0, \frac{1}{2})$. Put $x_N = N\varepsilon_N$.*

(a) For every $0 < \varepsilon < \frac{1}{2}$,

$$\widetilde{C}_N = \Big(1 - \frac{c}{N}\Big)^{-1} C_{N+1},$$

where C_{N+1} is the center of the walk with $N + 1$ steps and the same ε.

The center of a walk with an even number of steps is reached from the two central bins one step earlier, and from each of them with the same probability. So the two central bins of an odd N are the center of $N + 1$ up to the factor $1 - c/N$, and what we know about the crossing for even N carries over. Proposition S3.1 of Online Resource 1 shows that the crossing for odd N satisfies Theorem 2.7, that $P_N(0) < P_N(1)$ at the crossing for odd $N \ge 1689$, and that the law at the crossing is convex between the humps for every large odd N.

Proof. The crossing. By Proposition 2.3, $P_N(k)/E_N$ is strictly increasing in ε for $k = \frac{N+1}{2}$. It tends to 0 as $\varepsilon \to 0$. At $\varepsilon = \frac{1}{2}$ the steps are independent and fair, so $\widetilde{C}_N = \binom{N}{k} 2^{-N} > 2^{-N} = E_N$. So the ratio equals 1 at exactly one ε_N, and $\varepsilon_N < \frac{1}{2}$.

(a) Put $k = \frac{N+1}{2}$. Since $\varepsilon + \frac{c}{2} = \frac{1}{2}$, we have $r_N(k) = \frac{1}{2} + \frac{c}{2N}$ and $r_N(k-1) = \frac{1}{2} - \frac{c}{2N}$. So (1) with $t = N$ and $a = k$ gives

$$C_{N+1} = P_{N+1}(k) = \Big(\frac{1}{2} - \frac{c}{2N}\Big)\big(P_N(k) + P_N(k-1)\big) = \Big(1 - \frac{c}{N}\Big)\widetilde{C}_N.$$

□

Proposition 3.26 (the center for $8 \le N \le 2000$, computer-assisted)**.** *For every even $8 \le N \le 2000$, at the crossing, $P_N(a) > C_N$ for every $1 \le a \le N - 1$ with $a \ne h$.*

Proof. Let $8 \le N \le 2000$ be even. By Proposition 3.24, $D_N(a) > 0$ for $2m^* + 1 \le a \le N - 2m^* - 1$ and every mode. For $N \ge 10$ the script `certify_center.py` encloses ε_N and the law P_N in the same way as `certify_convex.py`, lists every index $a^* \ge N/2$ that can be a mode, and checks that

$2(N-a^*)+1 \le N/2$ for each of them. For $N=8$ Lean checks the same, with an enclosure as in the proof of Proposition 3.24 for $N \le 9$. This holds for every even N in the range. So Lemma 3.22 applies. □

As a second check, for each even $N \ge 10$ in the range the script also tests directly that the enclosure of $P_N(a) - P_N(h)$ is positive for every $1 \le a \le N-1$ with $a \ne h$, and this succeeds for all 996 values of N. The smallest value of $N/2 - (2m^*+1)$ is 1, at $N=8$ and at $N=12$.

Remark 3.27 (what is still open). We do not compute the constant N_1 of Theorem 3.21. The constants of Theorem 3.9 are explicit, but the proof uses them only through a limit. Even if we followed them, Step 3 needs $f_L(\frac{3}{2}\lambda_L + \frac{1}{2}\log x) < \frac{1}{2} f_L(\lambda_L)$ up to the error Θ_N. Numerically f_L falls to half of its maximum at $\lambda = 2.432$. So even without the error Θ_N, Step 3 needs $\frac{3}{2}\lambda_L + \frac{1}{2}\log x > 2.432$, that is, $x > 252.8$. Since $x_N + \log x_N$ is close to $2\log N - \log 8$ (Theorem 2.7), this means that N is above about $3.5 \cdot 10^{56}$. So the N between N_c and N_1 (or the threshold N_1' of Proposition S3.1(c) of Online Resource 1 for odd N) are open, and no computation can reach these constants as the proof stands. By Corollary 3.20 (and Proposition S3.1(b) of Online Resource 1 for odd N) the whole range would be closed by an effective proof of the single inequality $D_N(a_1) > 0$ at one point $m^* < a_1 \le 2m^*+1$. Near $2m^*$ the Landau heuristic suggests second differences of size $3/[x^3(\log x)^4]$, since $f_L''(\lambda) \sim 6/\lambda^4$ and $\lambda \approx \log x$ there. The pointwise error in Theorem 3.9 is much larger, so it does not prove the needed sign.

4 Verification

The proofs use three certified computations, apart from short exact ratios such as those in Proposition 3.7. First, `certify_elephant.py` encloses the 60-term sum in Theorem 2.6(b) in $[102.586396, 102.586398]$. With the analytic tail, it is below 102.59, giving the constant 5200. Any finite bound suffices asymptotically, but this value determines the explicit thresholds in Proposition 3.7 and the second-order results. Second, the same script certifies the Landau derivative and curvature enclosures of Lemma 3.10. Lean checks these independently.

Third, `certify_convex.py` brackets each crossing for $10 \le N \le 2000$ and encloses the law throughout that bracket, checking every possible mode and the required second differences (Proposition 3.24). The separate `certify_center.py` proves Proposition 3.26 and the finite part of Proposition 3.7. For $5 \le N \le 9$, the stated convexity and center checks are kernel-checked in Lean. The outputs and rational witnesses are in `data/certify_convex_output_2026-10-17.txt`, `data/certify_center_output_2026-10-17.txt`, `data/witnesses_convex_2026-10-17.jsonl`, and `data/witnesses_center_2026-10-17.jsonl`. The witnesses record script hashes and software versions. Each certification script fails if a required check fails, and range-based scripts also reject empty ranges.

The Lean 4.33.1 library in `kagey-problems/problem131/lean/PaperD` proves the finite identities, crossing bounds, sign arguments and certificate checks. The bulk and eventual-shape proofs use six named classical inputs, namely Fourier inversion, the compound Poisson characteristic function, Efron–Stein, Scheffé, unimodality of class-L laws, and Hoeffding's hypergeometric bound. Their sources and precise formal status are in `MAP.md` and `coverage_tables.tex`. The library uses Mathlib revision `0df444a360ea`; the recorded kernel build reports only `propext`, `Classical.choice` and `Quot.sound`. Generated certificate rows are checked with exact outward-rounded integer arithmetic, without `native_decide`. This does not formalize the six classical inputs or Conjecture 3.14.

The separate Python runs used Python 3.14.3, python-flint 0.9.0 (FLINT 3.6.0, including Arb), mpmath 1.3.0, numpy 2.4.2 and scipy 1.17.1. The figures, tables and other numerical illustrations are not proof inputs. Further checks and rerun commands are documented in the repository named under Code availability.

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A note on the use of AI

I wrote the original draft and its mathematics. I used Claude Opus 5.5 (Anthropic) for revision and proof checking, and later used OpenAI Codex to revise the exposition and check references. This included the abstract, introduction and description of the verification, and moving auxiliary proofs to the Online Resource. AI tools also generated the Lean files and parts of the verification code, which I reviewed against the paper. Section 4 distinguishes the formal proofs, their named classical hypotheses and the separate numerical checks. I checked the revisions and take responsibility for all mathematical claims, proofs and computations.

Statements and Declarations

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Data availability. The outputs of the computations described in Section 4 are in the folder `kagey-problems/problem131/paperD/data` of the repository named under Code availability. Online Resource 1 is the file `online_resource.pdf` in the folder `kagey-problems/problem131/paperD`, built from `online_resource.tex`.

Code availability. All code, data and Lean files supporting this paper are in the folder `kagey-problems/problem131` of `https://github.com/apemm/Kagey-Problems`. The supporting code, certificate records and Lean files are those at commit `c98db255026b` of that repository. To rerun the checks, run `python -B verify_all.py --paper d` in that folder, which takes several minutes. The certified computations behind Propositions 3.24 and 3.26 take about an hour and half an hour, and run separately in `paperD` as `python -B certify_convex.py 10 2000` and `python -B certify_center.py 10 2000`. The scripts need `numpy`, `scipy`, `mpmath` and `python-flint`, and the file `SUPPLEMENT.md` says what each script checks.

Use of AI tools. See the note on the use of AI tools just before these declarations.

Author contributions. I am the sole author and am responsible for the whole paper.

A Proofs for Section 2

We prove Theorem 2.6. Throughout, $N \geq 2$ is even and we condition on $X_1 = +1$. By Proposition 2.5(a) we need to bound $V_{t+1}(1)$, and we compare V with explicit hitting probabilities of Pólya urns. Let $\mathcal{L}_s F(b) = (1-r_s(b))F(b)+r_s(b)F(b+1)$, so that $V_s = \mathcal{L}_s V_{s+1}$ and $V_N(b) = \mathbf{1}\{b = h\}$. Both M_t and $t - M_t \geq 1$ are nondecreasing. So from $b \geq 1$ the chain stays at states ≥ 1, and for $1 \leq b \leq s-1$ we have $V_s(b) = 0$ unless b is feasible, that is, $b \in \mathcal{S}_s = \{b \in \mathbb{Z} : 1 \leq b \leq h,\ 1 \leq s - b \leq h\}$. Note that $\mathcal{S}_N = \{h\}$.

For $c \geq 0$ the Pólya(c) chain moves at time s from b to $b+1$ with probability $r_s^c(b) = \frac{b+c}{s+2c}$. It is Pólya's urn with weights $b+c$ and $s-b+c$ for the two colors, that is, with c extra balls of each color. For $b+c > 0$ and $s-b+c > 0$ let $\Phi_s^c(b) = \binom{N-s}{h-b}\mathrm{B}(h+c, h+c)/\mathrm{B}(b+c, s-b+c)$, where B is the beta function and the binomial coefficient is 0 unless $0 \leq h-b \leq N-s$. Theorem 2.6(a) will follow from Lemma A.1(d), and (b) from Proposition A.4.

Lemma A.1. *Let $c \geq 0$, $1 \leq s \leq N$, $b+c > 0$ and $s-b+c > 0$.*

(a) The number $\Phi_s^c(b)$ is the probability that the Pólya(c) chain at b at time s is at h at time N. So $\Phi_N^c(b) = \mathbf{1}\{b = h\}$, and $\Phi_s^c(b) = r_s^c(b)\Phi_{s+1}^c(b+1) + (1 - r_s^c(b))\Phi_{s+1}^c(b)$ for $s < N$.

(b) If $s < N$ and $\Phi_s^c(b) > 0$, then $r_s^c(b)\Phi_{s+1}^c(b+1)/\Phi_s^c(b) = \bar{r}_s(b) := \frac{h-b}{N-s}$.

(c) If $0 < \varepsilon < \frac{1}{2}$ and $\alpha = \frac{\varepsilon}{1-2\varepsilon}$, then $r_s(b) = r_s^{\alpha s}(b)$ for $0 \leq b \leq s$.

(d) If $0 < \varepsilon < \frac{1}{2}$ and $0 \leq c \leq \alpha s$, then $V_s(b) \geq \Phi_s^c(b)$ for $1 \leq b \leq s-1$. In particular $V_{t+1}(1) \geq \Phi_{t+1}^0(1) = \pi_t$ for $1 \leq t \leq h$.

Proof. (a) Let $x = b+c$, $y = s-b+c$ and $(x)_k = x(x+1)\cdots(x+k-1)$. As in the proof of Lemma 2.4, each order of the $N-s$ draws with $h-b$ draws of the first color has probability $(x)_{h-b}(y)_{N-s-h+b}/(x+y)_{N-s} = \mathrm{B}(h+c, h+c)/\mathrm{B}(x,y)$, and there are $\binom{N-s}{h-b}$ such orders. The recursion is the Markov property.

(b) Use $\binom{N-s-1}{h-b-1}/\binom{N-s}{h-b} = \frac{h-b}{N-s}$ and $\mathrm{B}(x,y)/\mathrm{B}(x+1,y) = \frac{x+y}{x} = 1/r_s^c(b)$.

(c) Since $1 + 2\alpha = 1/(1-2\varepsilon)$, we have $\frac{b+\alpha s}{s+2\alpha s} = (1-2\varepsilon)(\frac{b}{s} + \alpha) = r_s(b)$.

(d) We check the hypotheses of Lemma A.2(b) below for $F_u = \Phi_u^c$ on $\{1, \ldots, u-1\}$, where $s \leq u \leq N$. The reason is that M has $\alpha u \geq c$ extra balls at time u, so it is pulled toward $\frac{u}{2}$ at least as strongly as the Pólya(c) chain, and from a state closer to $\frac{u}{2}$ it is easier to end at h.

By (a), $F_N(b) = \mathbf{1}\{b = h\}$, and F_u vanishes off $\mathcal{S}_u$ because the binomial coefficient does. Let $s \leq u < N$ and $b \in \mathcal{S}_u$. Subtracting the recursion in (a) from the definition of $\mathcal{L}_u$ gives

$$\mathcal{L}_u F_{u+1}(b) - F_u(b) = \big(r_u(b) - r_u^c(b)\big)\big(F_{u+1}(b+1) - F_{u+1}(b)\big).$$

We show that the two factors on the right never have opposite signs. For the first factor, $r_u^c(b) = \frac{1}{2} - (\frac{u}{2} - b)/(u+2c)$, and by (c) the same formula with αu in place of c gives $r_u(b)$. So the first factor is $\frac{u}{2} - b$ times $\frac{1}{u+2c} - \frac{1}{u+2\alpha u}$. The second of these is nonnegative because $c \leq \alpha s \leq \alpha u$. Hence the first factor has the sign of $\frac{u}{2} - b$ or vanishes. For the second factor there are three cases. If $b = h$ then $b \geq \frac{u}{2}$ and $F_{u+1}(b+1) = 0$, so the factor is ≤ 0. If $u - b = h$ then $b \leq \frac{u}{2}$ and $F_{u+1}(b) = 0$, so the factor is ≥ 0. Otherwise both values are positive, and the formula for Φ gives $F_{u+1}(b+1)/F_{u+1}(b) = \frac{(h-b)(u-b+c)}{(h-u+b)(b+c)}$. With $b = \frac{u}{2} - d$ the numerator minus the denominator is $2d(h+c)$, so the ratio is ≥ 1 if $b \leq \frac{u}{2}$ and ≤ 1 if $b \geq \frac{u}{2}$. In all three cases the second factor has the sign of $\frac{u}{2} - b$ or vanishes. Hence $\mathcal{L}_u F_{u+1} \geq F_u$ on $\mathcal{S}_u$, and Lemma A.2(b) with $s_0 = s$ gives $V_s \geq F_s$. Finally $\Phi_{t+1}^0(1) = \beta_{t+1}(h) = \pi_t$ by (a) and Lemma 2.4. □

Lemma A.2. *Let $1 \le s_0 \le N$, and for $s_0 \le s \le N$ let $F_s \ge 0$ be a function on $\{1, \dots, s-1\}$.*

(a) If $F_N(h) \ge 1$ and $\mathcal{L}_s F_{s+1} \le K_s F_s$ on $\mathcal{S}_s$ for $s_0 \le s < N$, with constants $K_s \ge 0$, then $V_s \le \big(\prod_{u=s}^{N-1} K_u\big) F_s$ on $\mathcal{S}_s$.

(b) If $F_N(b) \le \mathbf{1}\{b = h\}$, each F_s vanishes off $\mathcal{S}_s$, and $\mathcal{L}_s F_{s+1} \ge F_s$ on $\mathcal{S}_s$ for $s_0 \le s < N$, then $V_s \ge F_s$.

Proof. We use backward induction on s, from $V_N(b) = \mathbf{1}\{b = h\}$ and $V_s = \mathcal{L}_s V_{s+1}$. Note that $\mathcal{L}_s$ is an average of two values, so it keeps inequalities between functions. In (a), suppose that $V_{s+1} \le \prod_{u>s} K_u \, F_{s+1}$ on $\mathcal{S}_{s+1}$. This also holds off $\mathcal{S}_{s+1}$, because there $V_{s+1} = 0$ and $F_{s+1} \ge 0$. So on $\mathcal{S}_s$ we get $V_s = \mathcal{L}_s V_{s+1} \le \prod_{u>s} K_u \, \mathcal{L}_s F_{s+1} \le \prod_{u \ge s} K_u \, F_s$. In (b), suppose that $V_{s+1} \ge F_{s+1}$ on $\{1, \dots, s\}$. Then $V_s = \mathcal{L}_s V_{s+1} \ge \mathcal{L}_s F_{s+1} \ge F_s$ on $\mathcal{S}_s$, and $F_s = 0 \le V_s$ off $\mathcal{S}_s$. □

Idea of the proof of the upper bound. We compare M with an urn whose number of extra balls, $\kappa(s+10)$ of each color at time s, grows more than twice as fast as the αs of M. Its hitting probability $\Phi_s^{\kappa_s}$ is explicit. One step of M applied to it gives it back times a factor Δ_s, and Proposition A.4 shows that $\log \Delta_s \le \kappa/s$ up to a smaller term. Two effects enter Δ_s. Raising the extra balls from κ_s to κ_{s+1} changes Φ, and we bound this through the derivative of Φ_s^τ in τ (Lemma A.3). Also M pulls toward the middle less than the comparison urn, which helps. The product of the factors is about $e^{\kappa H_N}$. Let ψ be the digamma function.

Lemma A.3. *Let $2 \le s \le N$, $b \in \mathcal{S}_s$ and $\tau \ge 0$. Put $X = b + \tau$, $Y = s - b + \tau$, $\Sigma = X + Y$ and $z = (s - 2b)^2/\Sigma^2$. Then*

$$\partial_\tau \log \Phi_s^\tau(b) < -\log(1 - z) + \frac{1 + z}{(1 - z)\Sigma} + \frac{2(1 + z)}{3\Sigma^2(1 - z)^2}.$$

Proof. We differentiate the beta functions and bound the digamma function by the first terms of its expansion. Only the two beta functions in $\Phi_s^\tau(b)$ depend on τ, and $\log \mathrm{B}(x, y) = \log \Gamma(x) + \log \Gamma(y) - \log \Gamma(x + y)$. So the derivative is $2\psi(\Sigma) - \psi(X) - \psi(Y)$ minus the difference $2\psi(N + 2\tau) - 2\psi(h + \tau)$. The duplication formula [35, 5.5.5] gives $2\psi(2y) = \psi(y) + \psi(y + \frac{1}{2}) + 2\log 2$, and ψ is increasing. With $y = h + \tau$ this shows that the difference we subtract is more than $2 \log 2$. For $x > 0$, [35, 5.9.15] writes $\log x - \frac{1}{2x} - \psi(x)$ as $2\int_0^\infty \frac{t \, dt}{(t^2 + x^2)(e^{2\pi t} - 1)}$, which lies in $(0, \frac{1}{12x^2})$ since $\int_0^\infty \frac{t \, dt}{e^{2\pi t} - 1} = \frac{1}{24}$. So $\psi(\Sigma) < \log \Sigma - \frac{1}{2\Sigma}$, and $\psi(x) > \log x - \frac{1}{2x} - \frac{1}{12x^2}$ for $x = X$ and $x = Y$. Hence the derivative is less than $\log \frac{\Sigma^2}{4XY} + (\frac{1}{2X} + \frac{1}{2Y} - \frac{1}{\Sigma}) + \frac{1}{12}(\frac{1}{X^2} + \frac{1}{Y^2})$. Now $X - Y = 2b - s$, so $4XY = \Sigma^2 - (X - Y)^2 = \Sigma^2(1 - z)$ and $X^2 + Y^2 = \Sigma^2(1 + z)/2$. So the three terms are $-\log(1 - z)$, $\frac{X^2 + Y^2}{2XY\Sigma} = \frac{1 + z}{(1 - z)\Sigma}$ and $\frac{X^2 + Y^2}{12X^2Y^2} = \frac{2(1 + z)}{3\Sigma^2(1 - z)^2}$. □

Proposition A.4. *Let $0 < \varepsilon < \frac{1}{4}$, $\kappa = \frac{2\varepsilon}{1 - 4\varepsilon}$, $\kappa_s = \kappa(s + 10)$ and $\Sigma_s = s + 2\kappa_s$. For $1 \le s \le N - 1$ and $b \in \mathcal{S}_s$ let $\Delta_s(b) = \mathcal{L}_s \Phi_{s+1}^{\kappa_{s+1}}(b) / \Phi_s^{\kappa_s}(b)$.*

(a) Let $c = \kappa_s$, $c' = \kappa_{s+1}$, $d = \frac{s}{2} - b$, $u = \frac{d}{s + 2c'}$, $v = \frac{d}{N - s}$ and $\rho = \frac{s + 2c'}{s(1 + 2\alpha)}$. Then $|u| < \frac{1}{2}$ and

$$\Delta_s(b) = \mathcal{J} \, \frac{\Phi_s^{c'}(b)}{\Phi_s^{c}(b)}, \qquad \mathcal{J} = 1 - (\rho - 1)\frac{u(u + v)}{\frac{1}{4} - u^2}.$$

(b) The factor satisfies $\log \Delta_s(b) \le \frac{\kappa}{\Sigma_s} + \frac{2\kappa}{3\Sigma_s^2}$.

(c) For $1 \le t \le h$, $V_{t+1}(1) \le \pi_t \exp\big(\kappa\big[H_{N-1} - H_t + \frac{2}{3t}\big] + \kappa_{t+1}\big[\log\frac{(t+1)^2}{4t} + \frac{2}{3}\big]\big)$.

(d) The center satisfies $C_N \le U_N := \varepsilon c_1 e^{\kappa H_{N-1}} \sum_{t=1}^{h} w_t (1-\varepsilon)^{t-1} e^{\kappa \mathcal{G}(t)}$, *where* $\mathcal{G}(t) = (t+11)\big(\log\frac{(t+1)^2}{4t} + \frac{2}{3}\big) - H_t + \frac{2}{3t}$.

The slope κ solves $2(\kappa-\alpha)/(1+2\alpha) = \kappa$, so that in (b) the gain in $\mathcal{J}$ cancels the main loss from raising the extra balls from c to c'.

Proof. (a) Write $r' = r_s^{c'}(b)$, $\bar r = \bar r_s(b)$ and $r = r_s(b)$. By Lemma A.1(b) with c', and the recursion in Lemma A.1(a), we have $r'\Phi_{s+1}^{c'}(b+1) = \bar r\,\Phi_s^{c'}(b)$ and $(1-r')\Phi_{s+1}^{c'}(b) = (1-\bar r)\Phi_s^{c'}(b)$. So the numerator of $\Delta_s(b)$ divided by $\Phi_s^{c'}(b)$ is $\frac{(1-r)(1-\bar r)}{1-r'} + \frac{r\bar r}{r'}$. Here $r' = \frac12 - u$, $\bar r = \frac12 + v$ and $r = \frac12 - \rho u$, since $\frac12 - r = (1-2\varepsilon)\frac{d}{s} = \rho u$. Over the denominator $r'(1-r') = \frac14 - u^2$ the numerator is $f(u,v) + f(-u,-v)$ with $f(u,v) = (\frac12 + \rho u)(\frac12 - v)(\frac12 - u)$, and this equals $\frac14 - \rho u^2 - (\rho-1)uv$. Also $|d| \le \frac{s}{2} - 1$, so $|u| < \frac12$.

(b) *Step 1. The factor* $\mathcal{J}$. Write $c = \kappa_s$, $c' = c + \kappa$ and $\Sigma = \Sigma_s$. Since $c' - \alpha s = (\kappa - \alpha)s + 11\kappa$, the choice of κ gives $\rho - 1 = \kappa + \nu_s$ with $\nu_s = \frac{22\kappa}{s(1+2\alpha)}$. As u and v have the sign of d, $u(u+v) \ge u^2$. So $\mathcal{J} \le 1 - (\kappa+\nu_s)W'$ with $z' = 4u^2$ and $W' = \frac{z'}{1-z'}$. Also $\mathcal{J} > 0$ by (a), since $0 < r < 1$ and $\bar r$, $1 - \bar r$ are not both 0. So $\log \mathcal{J} \le -(\kappa+\nu_s)W'$.

Step 2. The ratio $\Phi_s^{c'}/\Phi_s^c$. The logarithm $\log(\Phi_s^{c'}(b)/\Phi_s^c(b))$ is the integral over $\tau \in [c, c']$ of the derivative in Lemma A.3. Its bound increases in z and decreases in Σ, while z decreases and Σ increases in τ. So we may take the bound at $\tau = c$, where $X + Y = \Sigma$, and multiply it by the length κ of the interval. Put $W = \frac{z}{1-z}$. Then $\frac{1}{1-z} = 1 + W$, $\frac{1+z}{1-z} = 1 + 2W$ and $-\log(1-z) \le W$, so

$$\log \Delta_s(b) \le \kappa\Big[W + \frac{1+2W}{\Sigma} + \frac{2(1+2W)(1+W)}{3\Sigma^2}\Big] - (\kappa+\nu_s)W'. \tag{4}$$

Step 3. What is left to show. The terms of (4) without W and W' are $\frac{\kappa}{\Sigma} + \frac{2\kappa}{3\Sigma^2}$, which is the bound we want. Since $(1+2W)(1+W) = 1 + 3W + 2W^2$, the other terms are

$$\kappa(W - W') + \frac{2\kappa W}{\Sigma} + \frac{2\kappa W}{\Sigma^2} + \frac{4\kappa W^2}{3\Sigma^2} - \nu_s W',$$

and we must show that they add up to at most 0. If $W = 0$ then $d = 0$, so $W' = 0$ and there is nothing to do. So let $W > 0$. The first four terms are positive, and we show that each is a small multiple of $\frac{\kappa}{s}W$. The last term is negative (it comes from the shift 10 in κ_s), and it is a larger multiple of $\frac{\kappa}{s}W$. We need three facts, with $X = b + c$ and $Y = s - b + c$ as in Step 2.

(i) We have $1 + W \le \frac{\Sigma}{2(1+c)}$. Indeed $X, Y \ge 1 + c$, since $b \ge 1$ and $s - b \ge 1$, and the larger of X and Y is at least $\frac{\Sigma}{2}$. So $XY \ge (1+c)\Sigma/2$, and $1 + W = \frac{1}{1-z} = \frac{\Sigma^2}{4XY}$.

(ii) We have $W - W' \le \frac{2\kappa}{1+c}W$, and so $W' \ge \frac{9}{11}W$. Indeed z and z' have the same numerator $(s-2b)^2$, and their denominators are Σ^2 and $(s+2c')^2 = (\Sigma+2\kappa)^2$. So $z' = \lambda z$ with $\lambda = (\frac{\Sigma}{\Sigma+2\kappa})^2 \ge 1 - \frac{4\kappa}{\Sigma}$. Then

$$W - W' = \frac{(1-\lambda)z}{(1-z)(1-\lambda z)} \le (1-\lambda)W(1+W) \le \frac{4\kappa}{\Sigma}\,W\,\frac{\Sigma}{2(1+c)} = \frac{2\kappa}{1+c}W,$$

where we used $1 - \lambda z \ge 1 - z$ and then (i). Since $c = \kappa(s+10) \ge 11\kappa$, we have $\frac{2\kappa}{1+c} \le \frac{2}{11}$.

(iii) We have $\Sigma \ge s$, $1 + c > \kappa s$ and $\Sigma^2 \ge 3s$. The first two are clear. For the third, $W > 0$ means $s \ne 2b$, and with $b \ge 1$ and $s - b \ge 1$ this forces $s \ge 3$.

Step 4. The terms with W. We bound the four positive terms one by one.

$$\begin{aligned}
\kappa(W-W') &\le \frac{2\kappa^2}{1+c}W \le \frac{2\kappa}{s}W && \text{by (ii) and } 1+c>\kappa s,\\
\frac{2\kappa W}{\Sigma} &\le \frac{2\kappa}{s}W && \text{by } \Sigma \ge s,\\
\frac{2\kappa W}{\Sigma^2} &\le \frac{2\kappa}{3s}W && \text{by } \Sigma^2 \ge 3s,\\
\frac{4\kappa W^2}{3\Sigma^2} &\le \frac{4\kappa W(1+W)}{3\Sigma^2} \le \frac{2\kappa W}{3\Sigma(1+c)} \le \frac{2\kappa}{3s}W && \text{by (i) and } \Sigma \ge s.
\end{aligned}$$

The four bounds add up to $\frac{16\kappa}{3s}W$. For the negative term, (ii) gives $-\nu_s W' \le -\frac{9}{11}\nu_s W = -\frac{18\kappa}{s(1+2\alpha)}W$. So

$$\log \Delta_s(b) \le \frac{\kappa}{\Sigma} + \frac{2\kappa}{3\Sigma^2} + W\Big[\frac{16\kappa}{3s} - \frac{18\kappa}{s(1+2\alpha)}\Big],$$

and the bracket is negative because $1+2\alpha<2$ for $\varepsilon<\frac14$, so $18/(1+2\alpha)>9>16/3$.

(c) We first compare $V_{t+1}(1)$ with $\Phi_{t+1}^{\kappa_{t+1}}(1)$, and then this with $\pi_t=\Phi_{t+1}^0(1)$. For the first step apply Lemma A.2(a) with $s_0=t+1$, $F_s=\Phi_s^{\kappa_s}$ and $K_s=\exp(\frac{\kappa}{s}+\frac{2\kappa}{3s^2})$. This is allowed, since $F_N(h)=1$, $F_s>0$ on $\mathcal{S}_s$, and $\mathcal{L}_s F_{s+1}=\Delta_s F_s\le K_s F_s$ on $\mathcal{S}_s$ by (b) and $\Sigma_s\ge s$. The product of the K_s over $t<s<N$ is the exponential of $\kappa(H_{N-1}-H_t)+\frac{2\kappa}{3}\sum_{s>t}s^{-2}$, and $\sum_{s>t}s^{-2}\le\frac1t$. Since $1\in\mathcal{S}_{t+1}$, we get $V_{t+1}(1)\le e^{\kappa[H_{N-1}-H_t+2/(3t)]}\,\Phi_{t+1}^{\kappa_{t+1}}(1)$.

For the second step, $\log(\Phi_{t+1}^{\kappa_{t+1}}(1)/\pi_t)$ is the integral over $\tau\in[0,\kappa_{t+1}]$ of the derivative in Lemma A.3 with $s=t+1$ and $b=1$. As in Step 2 of (b), the bound of that lemma is largest at $\tau=0$. There $X=1$, $Y=t$ and $\frac{1}{1-z}=\frac{(t+1)^2}{4t}$, and the bound is $\log\frac{(t+1)^2}{4t}+\frac{t^2+1}{2t(t+1)}+\frac{t^2+1}{12t^2}\le\log\frac{(t+1)^2}{4t}+\frac23$, because the two fractions are at most $\frac12$ and $\frac16$ for $t\ge1$. Multiplying by the length κ_{t+1} of the interval gives (c).

(d) Insert (c) into Proposition 2.5(a), and use $\kappa_{t+1}=\kappa(t+11)$ and $\pi_t=c_1w_t$. □

Proof of Theorem 2.6. (a) By Proposition 2.5(a) and Lemma A.1(d), $C_N\ge\varepsilon c_1\sum_t w_t(1-\varepsilon)^{t-1}$. Now $(1-\varepsilon)^{t-1}\ge1-(t-1)\varepsilon$ and $\sum_t w_t(t-1)=2-\frac{6}{h+2}$ by Proposition 2.5(c). So $C_N\ge\varepsilon c_1(1-2\varepsilon)$, and $c_1=\frac{4}{N+2}$.

(b) *Step 1. The constants.* Let $0<\varepsilon(1+\log N)\le\frac{1}{100}$. Since $\log N\ge0$, we have $\varepsilon\le\frac{1}{100}$. So $1-4\varepsilon\ge0.96$ and $\kappa\le2\varepsilon/0.96\le2.1\varepsilon$. Also $\kappa\le2\varepsilon(1+8\varepsilon)$, because $(1+8\varepsilon)(1-4\varepsilon)=1+4\varepsilon(1-8\varepsilon)\ge1$. Since $\log\frac{(t+1)^2}{4t}\ge0$ and $\frac23(t+11)>1+\log t\ge H_t$, we have $\mathcal{G}(t)>0$. Since $\frac{(t+1)^2}{4t}\le\frac{t+1}{2}$, $\frac23<\log2$ and $H_t\ge\frac{2}{3t}$, also $\mathcal{G}(t)\le(t+11)\log(t+1)\le12t\log(t+1)$. So $\kappa\mathcal{G}(t)\le25.2\,\varepsilon t\log(t+1)$, and this is at most $\frac t2\log2$ for $t\le h$, since then $25.2\,\varepsilon\log(t+1)\le25.2\,\varepsilon\log N\le0.252<\frac12\log2$.

Step 2. The sum over t. Since $e^y-1\le ye^y$ for $y\ge0$, Step 1 gives $e^{\kappa\mathcal{G}(t)}-1\le\kappa\mathcal{G}(t)2^{t/2}$. By Proposition A.4(d), $(1-\varepsilon)^{t-1}\le1$, $\sum_t w_t=1$ and $w_t\le2t2^{-t}$ (Proposition 2.5(c)),

$$C_N\le\varepsilon c_1 e^{\kappa H_{N-1}}\Big(1+50.4\,\varepsilon\sum_{t\ge1}t^2\log(t+1)2^{-t/2}\Big),$$

and we bound the series as follows. The ratio of its consecutive terms is $(1+\frac1t)^2\frac{\log(t+2)}{\log(t+1)}2^{-1/2}$, which decreases in t and is below $\frac34$ at $t=60$. So the terms with $t>60$ add up to less than four times the term at $t=61$, and this is below 10^{-4}. The first 60 terms add up to 102.5864 to four decimals (enclosed in ball arithmetic by `certify_elephant.py`), so the series is below 102.59.

Step 3. The factor $e^{\kappa H_{N-1}}$. Finally $H_{N-1} \le 1 + \log N$, so $\kappa H_{N-1} \le 2\varepsilon \log N + 2\varepsilon + 16\varepsilon^2(1 + \log N) \le 2\varepsilon \log N + 3\varepsilon$. With $1 + y \le e^y$ this proves (b), since $3 + 50.4 \cdot 102.59 < 5200$. Any upper bound for the series below $(5200 - 3)/50.4$, which exceeds 103.1, would give the same constant. □

B The families and the mode

This appendix states the family estimates used for the mode bound in Corollary 3.11. Their proofs are in Online Resource 1, Section S4, in the order stated here, and also support its tail theorem. We keep the conventions of Section 3. All constants in this appendix are explicit. Online Resource 1 writes C for an absolute constant whose value may change from line to line. Since M is independent of X_1, $f_N(m) = \mathbb{P}(M_N = m)$. Every path of a chain $M^{[k_0]}$ is nondecreasing in time, and we use the paths of Y and $Z^{(j)}$ fixed after Lemma 3.3. The size $|\mathcal{T}_v|$ of the family has the law β_v of Lemma 2.4. Let $\bar\beta_v(s) = \mathbb{P}(|\mathcal{T}_v| \ge s)$, with $\bar\beta_v(s) = 1$ for $s \le 1$. By Pascal's rule $\binom{N-s}{v-1} - \binom{N-s-1}{v-1} = \binom{N-s-1}{v-2}$ the tail of β_v telescopes. So, for $1 \le s \le N-1$,

$$\bar\beta_v(s) = \binom{N-s}{v-1} \Big/ \binom{N-1}{v-1} = \prod_{i=1}^{v-1} \Big(1 - \frac{s-1}{N-i}\Big) \le e^{-(v-1)(s-1)/(N-1)}, \qquad \beta_v(s) = \frac{v-1}{N-s}\,\bar\beta_v(s), \tag{5}$$

where the product vanishes as soon as one factor does. Where they are defined, the ratios are

$$\frac{\beta_v(d)}{\beta_v(d-1)} = 1 - \frac{v-2}{N-d}, \qquad \frac{\bar\beta_v(s-1)}{\bar\beta_v(s)} = 1 + \frac{v-1}{N-s-v+2}. \tag{6}$$

Lemma B.1 (monotone sandwich)**.** *Let $0 \le a \le b \le N$. If $m_h \le a$, then $(b-a+1)f_N(b) \le \mathbb{P}(a \le M_N \le b)$. If $b \le m_h$, then $(b-a+1)f_N(a) \le \mathbb{P}(a \le M_N \le b)$.*

Lemma B.2 (tail)**.** *Let $0 < \varepsilon < 1$, $k_0 \ge 1$ and $t \ge k_0$. For every integer $z \ge 1$,*

$$\mathbb{P}\big(M_t^{[k_0]} \ge z\big) \le \frac{\varepsilon t H_z}{z}, \qquad \mathbb{E}M_t^{[k_0]} \le \varepsilon t \log \frac{t}{k_0}.$$

In particular $\mathbb{P}(M_N \ge z) \le xH_z/z$, and $\mathbb{P}(Z_s^{(j)} \ge z) \le xH_z/z$ for $j - 1 \le s \le N$.

Lemma B.3 (the first flipped family)**.** *For $1 \le d \le N-1$,*

$$\frac{x}{d(d+1)}\Big(1 - \frac{2x(N-d-1)}{N(d+2)}\Big) \le \mathbb{P}\big(|\mathcal{T}_V| = d\big) \le \frac{x}{d(d+1)}, \qquad \mathbb{P}\big(|\mathcal{T}_V| \ge d\big) \le x\Big(\frac{1}{d} - \frac{1}{N}\Big).$$

Proposition B.4 (local lower bound)**.** *Let $N \ge 64$, $0 < \varepsilon < 1$ and $2 \le m \le N/4$. Then $f_N(m) \ge \frac{x}{m(m+1)}(1 - e_1'(m)) \ge \frac{x}{m(m+1)}(1 - e_1(m))$, where*

$$e_1'(m) = 2\varepsilon H_{m+1} + \frac{xH_m}{m} + \frac{2x}{m+2} + 8\varepsilon \log N + 20me^{-m/9}$$

and

$$e_1(m) = 20\Big(\frac{x \log(m+1)}{m} + \varepsilon \log N + me^{-m/9}\Big).$$

Idea of the proof. We use the formula of Lemma 3.3. Given the time j of the first flip, the count M_N is $d - Y_d + Z^{(j)}_{N-d}$, where d is the size of the first flipped family. As d grows by one this quantity moves by at most one, so it hits m at some d close to m unless Y or Z is large. (If no step of the family flips back and the rest of the tree has no flip, then $Y = Z = 0$ and the quantity is d itself, which hits m at $d = m$.) The law β_j of d is nearly flat near m, and this gives almost the full weight $\beta_j(m)$. Then we sum over j. The error e_1 collects the chance that Y or Z is large, the small slope of β_j, and the first flips that come too late to be treated this way.

Lemma B.5 (mode bound)**.** *Let $N \geq 64$ and $x \geq 1$, and put $\bar{c} = \frac{1}{40}$ and $A_0 = 15400$. If $\varepsilon \log N \leq \bar{c}$ and $804x \log(x+2) \leq N$, then $m_h \leq A_0 x \log^2(x+1)$. In particular this holds if $\varepsilon \log N \leq \bar{c}$ and $A_0 x \log(x+2) \leq N/4$.*

C Proofs for the bulk

We prove Theorems 3.8 and 3.9, Lemma 3.10 and Corollary 3.11. We keep the notation of Section 3 and of Appendix B. So $\mathcal{T}$ is the tree of Lemma 3.1, $\mathcal{T}_v$ is the family of v, and μ_v is the mark of v. By Lemma 2.4 and the discussion after Lemma 3.1, $|\mathcal{T}_v|$ has the law β_v, with mean N/v, and $\sum_{v=2}^{N} \beta_v(d) = N/(d(d+1))$ for $1 \leq d \leq N-1$. Let

$$\Psi_N(\theta) = \sum_{d=1}^{N-1} \frac{e^{i\theta d} - 1}{d(d+1)}, \qquad \Psi_\infty(\theta) = \sum_{d \geq 1} \frac{e^{i\theta d} - 1}{d(d+1)}.$$

The law CP_N has the characteristic function $\widehat{\mathrm{CP}}_N(\theta) = e^{x\Psi_N(\theta)}$.

C.1 Proof of Theorem 3.8

Here we assume only $N \geq 1$ and $0 < \varepsilon < 1$. Let $Z_+ = \sum_{v=2}^{N} \mu_v |\mathcal{T}_v|$ be the total size of the flipped families.

Step 1: $M_N = Z_+$ with high probability. Two families are nested or disjoint. Suppose that no marked vertex has a marked strict descendant. Then the marked families are disjoint, each of their vertices has exactly one mark on its path to the root, and the other vertices have none. So $M_N = Z_+$ by Lemma 3.1. The number of pairs of a marked vertex and a marked strict descendant has mean $\varepsilon^2 \,\mathbb{E} \sum_v (|\mathcal{T}_v| - 1)$, since marks and tree are independent. Hence

$$\mathbb{P}(M_N \neq Z_+) \leq \varepsilon^2 \sum_{v=2}^{N} \Big(\frac{N}{v} - 1 \Big) = \varepsilon^2 (N H_N - 2N + 1).$$

Step 2. Given the tree, a product. Fix $\theta \in [-\pi, \pi]$. Given $\mathcal{T}$ the marks are independent, so $\mathbb{E}[e^{i\theta Z_+} \mid \mathcal{T}] = \prod_{v=2}^{N} (1 + a_v)$ with $a_v = \varepsilon(e^{i\theta|\mathcal{T}_v|} - 1)$. Here $|a_v| \leq 2\varepsilon$, $\operatorname{Re} a_v \leq 0$ and $|1 + a_v| = |1 - \varepsilon + \varepsilon e^{i\theta|\mathcal{T}_v|}| \leq 1$. Put $W = \sum_v a_v$, so that $\operatorname{Re} W \leq 0$ and $e^W = \prod_v e^{a_v}$ with $|e^{a_v}| \leq 1$. For complex a with $\operatorname{Re} a \leq 0$, Taylor's formula $e^a - 1 - a = a^2 \int_0^1 (1-s) e^{sa}\, ds$ gives $|e^a - (1+a)| \leq \frac{1}{2}|a|^2$. For complex numbers u_v and w_v of modulus at most 1 we have $|\prod_v u_v - \prod_v w_v| \leq \sum_v |u_v - w_v|$, by changing one factor at a time. So

$$\Big| \prod_v (1 + a_v) - e^W \Big| \leq \sum_{v=2}^{N} \tfrac{1}{2} |a_v|^2 \leq 2\varepsilon^2 (N-1).$$

Step 3. Replace W by its mean. Write $W = \varepsilon F$ with $F = \sum_{v=2}^{N}(e^{i\theta|\mathcal{T}_v|} - 1)$. Then $\mathbb{E}W = \varepsilon \sum_d (e^{i\theta d} - 1) \sum_v \beta_v(d) = x\Psi_N(\theta)$, which is $\log \widehat{\mathrm{CP}}_N(\theta)$. Put $\delta = W - \mathbb{E}W$. Taylor's formula for $s \mapsto e^{\mathbb{E}W + s\delta}$ on $[0,1]$ gives

$$e^W - e^{\mathbb{E}W} - e^{\mathbb{E}W}\delta = \delta^2 \int_0^1 (1-s)\, e^{\mathbb{E}W + s\delta}\, ds.$$

The exponent $\mathbb{E}W + s\delta = (1-s)\mathbb{E}W + sW$ has real part at most 0, so the right side has modulus at most $\frac{1}{2}|\delta|^2$. As $\mathbb{E}\delta = 0$, we get $|\mathbb{E}e^W - e^{\mathbb{E}W}| \le \frac{1}{2}\varepsilon^2 \operatorname{Var} F$, where $\operatorname{Var} F = \mathbb{E}|F - \mathbb{E}F|^2$.

Step 4. The variance of F. The variable F is a function of the independent parents $U_1, \dots, U_{N-1}$. Let $F^{(k)}$ be F with U_k replaced by an independent copy U_k'. The Efron–Stein inequality [27] says that $\operatorname{Var} F \le \frac{1}{2}\sum_k \mathbb{E}|F - F^{(k)}|^2$. It holds for every square-integrable function of independent variables [32], and it holds for the complex F because both sides are the sums of those for $\operatorname{Re} F$ and $\operatorname{Im} F$.

Replacing U_k by U_k' moves the family of $k+1$ from U_k to U_k'. So $|\mathcal{T}_v|$ changes only for vertices $v \ge 2$ on the path from U_k to the root or on the path from U_k' to the root. These paths do not depend on the choice at step k, since $U_k, U_k' \le k$. Let $\mathrm{dp}(u)$ be the depth of u, namely the number of edges between u and the root. There are at most $\mathrm{dp}(U_k) + \mathrm{dp}(U_k')$ such vertices, and each term of F moves by at most 2. Hence $\mathbb{E}|F - F^{(k)}|^2 \le 8\,\mathbb{E}[\mathrm{dp}(U_k)^2 + \mathrm{dp}(U_k')^2] = 16\,\mathbb{E}\,\mathrm{dp}(U_k)^2$.

Since $\mathrm{dp}(u+1) = 1 + \mathrm{dp}(U_u)$, the generating function $g_u(s) = \mathbb{E}s^{\mathrm{dp}(u)}$ satisfies $g_1 = 1$ and $u\, g_{u+1}(s) = s\sum_{j \le u} g_j(s)$. Subtracting the same identity for $u-1$ gives $u\, g_{u+1}(s) = (u - 1 + s)\, g_u(s)$ for $u \ge 2$, and $g_2(s) = s$. So $g_u(s) = \prod_{i=1}^{u-1} \frac{i-1+s}{i}$. So $\mathrm{dp}(u)$ is a sum of independent Bernoulli$(1/i)$ variables with $1 \le i < u$, and $\mathbb{E}\,\mathrm{dp}(u)^2 \le H_{u-1}^2 + H_{u-1}$. The parent U_k is uniform on $\{1, \dots, k\}$ and independent of the depths of $1, \dots, k$, so $\mathbb{E}\,\mathrm{dp}(U_k)^2 \le H_{k-1}^2 + H_{k-1}$. We get

$$\operatorname{Var} F \le \frac{1}{2}\sum_{k=1}^{N-1} 16\big(H_{k-1}^2 + H_{k-1}\big) = 8\sum_{k=0}^{N-2}\big(H_k^2 + H_k\big),$$

and the bound of Step 3 is at most $4\varepsilon^2 \sum_{k=0}^{N-2}(H_k^2 + H_k)$.

Step 5: Fourier inversion. For every integer m,

$$\mathbb{P}(Z_+ = m) - \mathrm{CP}_N(m) = \frac{1}{2\pi}\int_{-\pi}^{\pi} e^{-im\theta}\big(\mathbb{E}e^{i\theta Z_+} - \widehat{\mathrm{CP}}_N(\theta)\big)\, d\theta,$$

so the left side is at most $\sup_\theta |\mathbb{E}e^{i\theta Z_+} - \widehat{\mathrm{CP}}_N(\theta)|$ in absolute value. By Steps 2 to 4 this is at most $2\varepsilon^2(N-1) + 4\varepsilon^2 \sum_{k=0}^{N-2}(H_k^2 + H_k)$. Finally $|f_N(m) - \mathbb{P}(Z_+ = m)| \le \mathbb{P}(M_N \ne Z_+)$, and Step 1 bounds it. The three bounds add up to δ_Σ. For $\delta_\Sigma \le \delta_B$ we compare term by term. Since $H_N \le 1 + \log N$, we have $\varepsilon^2(NH_N - 2N + 1) \le \varepsilon^2 N \log N = x^2 \log N/N$. Next $2\varepsilon^2(N-1) \le 4\varepsilon^2 N \le \frac{4x^2}{N} e^{4x^2/N}$. Finally $H_k \le H_N$ for $k \le N-2$, so the sum is at most $4\varepsilon^2 N(H_N^2 + H_N) = 4x^2(H_N^2 + H_N)/N$. This proves Theorem 3.8. □

C.2 Proof of Theorem 3.9

We write $B(t) = -it\log|t| - \frac{\pi}{2}|t|$ for real $t \ne 0$, and $B(0) = 0$. For $t > 0$ this is the value of $u \log u$ at $u = -it$, with the principal logarithm, and $B(-t) = \overline{B(t)}$. We need three facts about Ψ_N and Ψ_∞.

Fact 1. For real θ, $|\Psi_N(\theta) - \Psi_\infty(\theta)| \le \sum_{d \ge N} \frac{2}{d(d+1)} = \frac{2}{N}$.

Fact 2. For $0 < |\theta| \le \pi$ we have $\Psi_\infty(\theta) = -i\theta\log(-i\theta) + R(\theta)$ with $|R(\theta)| \le \theta^2\big(0.631\,|\log|\theta|| + 1.53\big)$. The reason is that Ψ_∞ has a closed form in which θ enters only through $1 - e^{i\theta}$, and $1 - e^{i\theta}$ is close to $-i\theta$ for small θ. The term R is what this replacement changes. We prove it in the next four paragraphs.

We start with the closed form. For $0 < |s| \le 1$, $s \ne 1$,

$$\sum_{d\ge1} \frac{s^d - 1}{d(d+1)} = \chi(s) := \frac{(1-s)\log(1-s)}{s},$$

because $\frac{1}{d(d+1)} = \frac{1}{d} - \frac{1}{d+1}$, $\sum_d s^d/d = -\log(1-s)$, $\sum_d s^d/(d+1) = (-\log(1-s) - s)/s$ and $\sum_d \frac{1}{d(d+1)} = 1$. So $\Psi_\infty(\theta) = \chi(e^{i\theta})$.

Next we compare $1 - e^{i\theta}$ with $-i\theta$. Write $1 - e^{i\theta} = (-i\theta)\,\mathsf{u}$ with $\mathsf{u} = \operatorname{sinc}(\theta/2)\,e^{i\theta/2}$, where $\operatorname{sinc} y = \sin y/y$ is positive for $|y| \le \frac{\pi}{2}$. So u is close to 1 when θ is small. The argument of $-i\theta$ is $\mp\frac{\pi}{2}$ for $\pm\theta > 0$ and that of u is $\theta/2$. They add up to a number in $(-\frac{\pi}{2}, \frac{\pi}{2})$, so $\log(1 - e^{i\theta}) = \log(-i\theta) + \log\mathsf{u}$ for principal logarithms.

Now we get a formula for R. By the two steps above, $\chi(e^{i\theta}) = (-i\theta)\,\mathsf{u}e^{-i\theta}\big(\log(-i\theta) + \log\mathsf{u}\big)$. Subtracting $-i\theta\log(-i\theta)$ gives

$$R(\theta) = -i\theta\log(-i\theta)\big(\mathsf{u}e^{-i\theta} - 1\big) - i\theta\,\mathsf{u}e^{-i\theta}\log\mathsf{u}.$$

It remains to bound the three quantities in this formula. We show that

$$|\mathsf{u}e^{-i\theta} - 1| \le 0.631\,|\theta|, \qquad |\log\mathsf{u}| \le 0.53\,|\theta|, \qquad |\log(-i\theta)| \le |\log|\theta|| + \frac{\pi}{2}.$$

For the first, put $y = \theta/2$. Then $|\mathsf{u}e^{-i\theta} - 1| = |\operatorname{sinc} y - e^{iy}| \le (1 - \operatorname{sinc} y) + |1 - e^{iy}| \le \frac{y^2}{6} + |y| \le (\frac{1}{2} + \frac{\pi}{24})|\theta|$, where the last step uses $|\theta| \le \pi$, and $\frac{1}{2} + \frac{\pi}{24} \le 0.631$. For the second, $|\log\mathsf{u}|^2 = \log^2\operatorname{sinc}(\theta/2) + \theta^2/4$, and $-\log\operatorname{sinc} y = \sum_{k\ge1} \frac{\zeta(2k)}{k\pi^{2k}} y^{2k}$ has positive coefficients. So $|\log\operatorname{sinc}(\theta/2)|/|\theta|$ increases in $|\theta|$, and its value at $|\theta| = \pi$ gives $|\log\mathsf{u}| \le \big(\frac{1}{4} + \frac{\log^2(\pi/2)}{\pi^2}\big)^{1/2}|\theta| \le 0.53\,|\theta|$. The third holds because $-i\theta$ has modulus $|\theta|$ and argument $\pm\frac{\pi}{2}$. Since $|\mathsf{u}e^{-i\theta}| \le 1$, the formula for R now gives

$$|R(\theta)| \le |\theta|\Big(|\log|\theta|| + \frac{\pi}{2}\Big)\cdot 0.631\,|\theta| + |\theta|\cdot 0.53\,|\theta| \le \theta^2\big(0.631\,|\log|\theta|| + 1.53\big),$$

as $0.631\cdot\frac{\pi}{2} + 0.53 \le 1.53$.

Fact 3. For $|\theta| \le \pi$, $-\operatorname{Re}\Psi_\infty(\theta) = \sum_d \frac{1-\cos\theta d}{d(d+1)} \ge \frac{|\theta|}{2\pi}$. We may take $\theta \ne 0$. Keep only the terms with $d \le D := \lfloor\pi/|\theta|\rfloor$ and use $1 - \cos v \ge 2v^2/\pi^2$ for $|v| \le \pi$. This gives at least $\frac{2\theta^2}{\pi^2}\sum_{d\le D}\frac{d}{d+1} \ge \frac{\theta^2 D}{\pi^2} \ge \frac{|\theta|}{2\pi}$, since $D \ge \frac{\pi}{2|\theta|}$.

The function e^B is a characteristic function of class L. Let S_x have the law CP_∞ with parameter x, namely the law of $\sum_{d\ge1} d\,\mathcal{N}_d$. Its characteristic function is $e^{x\Psi_\infty(\theta)}$. By Fact 2, for $t \ne 0$ and $x \ge \max(1, |t|/\pi)$,

$$x\Psi_\infty(t/x) - it\log x = B(t) + xR(t/x), \qquad |xR(t/x)| \le \frac{t^2}{x}\big(0.631(|\log|t|| + \log x) + 1.53\big). \quad (7)$$

So the characteristic function of $(S_x - x\log x)/x$ tends to $e^{B(t)}$ as $x \to \infty$, for every real t. The limit is continuous at 0, so by Lévy's continuity theorem it is the characteristic function of a

probability law. It is integrable, so this law has the bounded continuous density f_L of Theorem 3.9. For $0 < c < 1$ and real t we have $B(ct) = cB(t) - ict \log c$, and hence

$$e^{B(t)} = e^{B(ct)} \cdot e^{B((1-c)t)}\, e^{it[(1-c)\log(1-c)+c\log c]}.$$

The last two factors form the characteristic function of a scaled and shifted copy of the law. So the law is of class L (self-decomposable), and f_L is unimodal by [28].

Proof of (a). By Fourier inversion on $\mathbb{Z}$ and the substitution $\theta = t/x$,

$$x\,\mathrm{CP}_N(m) = \frac{1}{2\pi}\int_{-\pi x}^{\pi x} e^{-i\lambda_m t} e^{A(t)}\,dt, \qquad A(t) = x\Psi_N(t/x) - it\log x.$$

Let $|t| \le \pi x$. By (7) and Fact 1,

$$|A(t) - B(t)| \le \frac{t^2}{x}\big(0.631(|\log|t|| + \log x) + 1.53\big) + \frac{2x}{N},$$

and by Facts 1 and 3, $\max(\mathrm{Re}\,A(t), \mathrm{Re}\,B(t)) \le -\frac{|t|}{2\pi} + \frac{2x}{N}$. Now $|e^A - e^B| \le |A - B|\, e^{\max(\mathrm{Re}\,A, \mathrm{Re}\,B)}$, and $\frac{2x}{N} \le \frac{1}{2}$ because $N \ge 4x$. So for $|t| \le \pi x$

$$|e^{A(t)} - e^{B(t)}| \le e^{1/2} e^{-|t|/2\pi}\Big[\frac{t^2}{x}\big(0.631(|\log|t|| + \log x) + 1.53\big) + \frac{2x}{N}\Big].$$

For $s \ge 1$ the tangent of the logarithm at 16 gives $\log s \le s/16 + \log 16 - 1$, and for $0 < s < 1$ we have $s|\log s| \le 1/e$. So $s^2|\log s| \le s^3/16 + (4\log 2 - 1)s^2 + s/e$ for every $s \ge 0$. We insert this with $s = |t|$ and integrate, using $\int_0^\infty t^k e^{-t/2\pi}\,dt = k!\,(2\pi)^{k+1}$. This gives

$$\frac{1}{2\pi}\int_{-\pi x}^{\pi x} |e^{A(t)} - e^{B(t)}|\,dt \le e^{1/2}\Big[\frac{K_0 + 16\pi^2 \cdot 0.631\log x}{x} + \frac{4x}{N}\Big],$$

where $K_0 = 6\pi^3 \cdot 0.631 + 16\pi^2\big(0.631(4\log 2 - 1) + 1.53\big) + 4\pi \cdot 0.631/e \le 538.6$. Beyond πx we use $|e^{B(t)}| = e^{-\pi|t|/2}$, which gives $\frac{1}{2\pi}\int_{|t|>\pi x} |e^{B(t)}|\,dt = \frac{2}{\pi^2} e^{-\pi^2 x/2} \le \frac{4}{\pi^4 x} \le \frac{0.042}{x}$, since $e^{-y} \le 1/y$ for $y > 0$. Since $f_L(\lambda_m) = \frac{1}{2\pi}\int_{\mathbb{R}} e^{-i\lambda_m t} e^{B(t)}\,dt$, the error is at most the sum of the two integrals. With $e^{1/2} \le 1.6488$ and $16\pi^2 \cdot 0.631 \le 99.66$ this sum is at most

$$\frac{1.6488 \cdot 538.6 + 0.042 + 1.6488 \cdot 99.66\log x}{x} + \frac{6.5952\,x}{N} \le \frac{889 + 165\log x}{x} + \frac{6.6\,x}{N}.$$

The second bound in (a) holds because $165 \le 889$. This proves (a). Fourier inversion on $\mathbb{Z}$ holds at every integer m, and $\mathrm{CP}_N(m) = 0$ for $m < 0$, so the proof covers every integer m.

Proof of (b). Since $\varepsilon \le \frac{1}{4}$, we have $N \ge 4x$. By Theorem 3.8, $|xf_N(m) - x\,\mathrm{CP}_N(m)| \le x\delta_\Sigma \le x\delta_B$. Add (a).

Proof of (c). We drop the index n. Let $x \to \infty$ and $x^3 \log^2 N/N \to 0$. Then $N \ge x \to \infty$, so $\log N \ge 1$ for large n, and $x/N \to 0$. Hence for large n we have $\varepsilon \le \frac{1}{4}$ and $x \ge 1$, and (b) applies. Its bound tends to 0, since $x\delta_B = O(x^3 \log^2 N/N)$. Only large n matter for convergence in law. Let U be uniform on $[0, 1)$ and independent of M_N. Then $(M_N + U - x\log x)/x$ has the density q_N with $q_N(\lambda) = xf_N(m)$ for $\lambda_m \le \lambda < \lambda_m + \frac{1}{x}$. On a compact set of λ the relevant m are nonnegative once x is large, and $|\lambda - \lambda_m| < \frac{1}{x}$. As f_L is uniformly continuous, $q_N \to f_L$ uniformly on compact sets. By Scheffé's lemma $q_N \to f_L$ in L^1, and since $U/x \to 0$ this gives the convergence in law. At the crossing $x_N \sim 2\log N$ by Theorem 2.7, so both conditions hold. □

C.3 Proof of Lemma 3.10

Step 1. A real integral. We claim that for every real λ and $k \geq 0$,

$$f_L^{(k)}(\lambda) = \frac{1}{\pi} \int_0^\infty (-s)^k \, e^{-s\log s - \lambda s} \sin(\pi s)\, ds. \tag{8}$$

For $k = 0$ this is [20, Eq. (4.3)], and we include a short proof. Since $B(-t) = \overline{B(t)}$, the definition of f_L gives $f_L(\lambda) = \frac{1}{\pi}\operatorname{Re}\int_0^\infty \Phi(-it)\,dt$ with $\Phi(u) = \exp(u\log u + \lambda u)$. The function Φ is holomorphic off the negative real axis. Put $u = \rho e^{i\varphi}$ with $-\pi < \varphi \leq -\frac{\pi}{2}$. Then $\operatorname{Re}(u\log u) = \rho(\log\rho\cos\varphi - \varphi\sin\varphi)$, where $\cos\varphi \leq 0$ and $\varphi\sin\varphi \geq 0$. For $\log\rho \geq |\lambda| + 1$ this gives $\operatorname{Re}(u\log u + \lambda u) \leq -\rho(|\cos\varphi| + \varphi\sin\varphi) \leq -\rho$, because $|\cos\varphi| + \varphi\sin\varphi \geq 1$ on $[-\pi, -\frac{\pi}{2}]$ (for $\psi = \varphi + \pi \in [0, \frac{\pi}{2}]$ it equals $\cos\psi + (\pi - \psi)\sin\psi \geq \cos\psi + \sin\psi \geq 1$). Also Φ is bounded near 0. So by Cauchy's theorem we may turn the ray $u = -it$ to the lower side of the negative real axis, where $u = -s$ and $\log u = \log s - i\pi$. There $u\log u = -s\log s + i\pi s$, and $dt = i\,du = -i\,ds$. Hence

$$f_L(\lambda) = \frac{1}{\pi}\operatorname{Re}\Big[-i\int_0^\infty e^{-s\log s - \lambda s}\, e^{i\pi s}\, ds\Big] = \frac{1}{\pi}\int_0^\infty e^{-s\log s - \lambda s}\sin(\pi s)\, ds.$$

The integrand decays faster than every exponential, so we may differentiate under the integral sign. This proves (8). Also f_L'' is bounded on the real line, because $t^2 e^{B(t)}$ is integrable and we may differentiate the Fourier formula for f_L twice.

Step 2. Certified enclosures. Let $-0.223 \leq \lambda \leq 0$ and $k \in \{1, 2\}$, and split the integral in (8) at $\delta = 2^{-20}$ and at 30. On $[0, \delta]$ we have $-s\log s \leq 1/e$, $-\lambda s \leq 0.223\, s$ and $|\sin\pi s| \leq \pi s$, so this part is at most $\pi e^{1/e + 0.223\delta}\delta^{k+2}/(k+2)$ in absolute value. On $[30, \infty)$ we have $s\log s + \lambda s \geq cs$ with $c = \log 30 - 0.223 > 3$, so this part is at most $\int_{30}^\infty s^2 e^{-cs}\, ds \leq 30^2 e^{-30c}$. Both are below 10^{-17}. On $[\delta, 30]$ the integrand is holomorphic in a neighborhood of the path, and we enclose the integral with the rigorous integration algorithm of [29], in ball arithmetic with 128 bits. The parameter λ enters as a ball, so one run encloses the integral for every λ in an interval. The script `certify_elephant.py` does this and reports

$$f_L'(-0.2229) \in [9.232\cdot 10^{-6}, 9.234\cdot 10^{-6}], \qquad f_L'(-0.2227) \in [-6.548\cdot 10^{-6}, -6.546\cdot 10^{-6}],$$

and $f_L''(\lambda) \in [-0.0792, -0.0786]$ for every $\lambda \in [-0.2229, -0.2227]$. In the same way it finds that f_L' is positive at -0.22278299 and negative at -0.22278297. The two enclosures are $6.8984026\cdot 10^{-10}$ and $-8.8809315\cdot 10^{-10}$ with radii below 10^{-17}, and these are the smallest margins in the proof.

Step 3. The mode. Write $[a, b] = [-0.2229, -0.2227]$. By Step 2, f_L' is strictly decreasing on $[a, b]$ with $f_L'(a) > 0 > f_L'(b)$. So f_L' has exactly one zero λ_{L} in $[a, b]$, and f_L is strictly increasing on $[a, \lambda_{\mathrm{L}}]$ and strictly decreasing on $[\lambda_{\mathrm{L}}, b]$. Since f_L is unimodal, there is a point λ_* such that f_L is nondecreasing on $(-\infty, \lambda_*]$ and nonincreasing on $[\lambda_*, \infty)$. If $\lambda_* > \lambda_{\mathrm{L}}$, then f_L would be nondecreasing just to the right of λ_{L}, which is false. In the same way $\lambda_* < \lambda_{\mathrm{L}}$ is impossible. So $\lambda_* = \lambda_{\mathrm{L}}$, and f_L is nondecreasing on $(-\infty, \lambda_{\mathrm{L}}]$ and nonincreasing on $[\lambda_{\mathrm{L}}, \infty)$. By Step 2 again, $\lambda_{\mathrm{L}} \in (-0.22278299, -0.22278297)$. This proves (a) and (b).

Step 4. The constant κ_L. Let $\delta_0 = \min(\lambda_{\mathrm{L}} - a, b - \lambda_{\mathrm{L}}) > 0$. For $|\lambda - \lambda_{\mathrm{L}}| \leq \delta_0$, Taylor's formula with $f_L'(\lambda_{\mathrm{L}}) = 0$ and $f_L'' \leq -0.078$ on $[a, b]$ gives $f_L(\lambda_{\mathrm{L}}) - f_L(\lambda) \geq 0.039(\lambda - \lambda_{\mathrm{L}})^2$. For $|\lambda - \lambda_{\mathrm{L}}| > \delta_0$ the monotonicity of Step 3 gives $f_L(\lambda) \leq f_L(\lambda_{\mathrm{L}} \pm \delta_0) \leq f_L(\lambda_{\mathrm{L}}) - 0.039\,\delta_0^2$. Since $\delta_0 < 1$, the bound in (c) holds with $0.039\,\delta_0^2$ in place of κ_L. By (a), $\lambda_{\mathrm{L}} - a > 0.2229 - 0.22278299 > 1.17\cdot 10^{-4}$ and $b - \lambda_{\mathrm{L}} > 0.22278297 - 0.2227 = 8.297\cdot 10^{-5}$, so $0.039\,\delta_0^2 > 0.039\cdot(8.297\cdot 10^{-5})^2 > 2.68\cdot 10^{-10}$. So (c) holds with $\kappa_L = 2.6\cdot 10^{-10}$. □

C.4 Proof of Corollary 3.11

The method is to compare f_N at a mode with f_N at the integer m' nearest to the predicted place $x\log x + \lambda_{\mathrm{L}} x$. By Theorem 3.9(b) both values are close to values of f_L, and f_L falls off quadratically away from λ_{L}. So a mode cannot be far from m'.

We first prove (a). So we assume (H), $E' < \kappa_L/2$ and $m_h \le N/4$, with E_1 and E' as in the statement.

Let m' be the integer nearest to $x\log x + \lambda_{\mathrm{L}} x$. This number increases in $x \ge 1$ and is at least $\lambda_{\mathrm{L}} > -\frac{1}{2}$, so $m' \ge 0$. Also $|\lambda_{m'} - \lambda_{\mathrm{L}}| \le \frac{1}{2x}$, and since $f_L'(\lambda_{\mathrm{L}}) = 0$, $f_L(\lambda_{m'}) \ge f_L(\lambda_{\mathrm{L}}) - \|f_L''\|_\infty/(8x^2)$. Let $\tilde m$ be a mode of f_N or $\tilde m = m^*$. We claim that $f_N(\tilde m) \ge f_N(m') - 16xH_N/N^2$. For a mode of f_N this is clear. For m^* we have $f_N(m^*) + f_N(N-m^*) = 2P_N(N-m^*) \ge 2P_N(N-m') \ge f_N(m')$. Here $N - m^* \ge \lceil N/2\rceil \ge \lceil N/4\rceil \ge m_h$. So f_N is nonincreasing on $\{\lceil N/4\rceil, \dots, N\}$ by Lemma 3.4. There are at least $N/4$ integers from $\lceil N/4\rceil$ to $\lceil N/2\rceil$. So Lemma B.1 (with $a = \lceil N/4\rceil \ge m_h$ and $b = \lceil N/2\rceil$) gives the second inequality below, and Lemma B.2 gives the third,

$$f_N(N-m^*) \le f_N(\lceil N/2\rceil) \le \frac{\mathbb{P}(M_N \ge \lceil N/4\rceil)}{N/4} \le \frac{16xH_N}{N^2}.$$

Now Theorem 3.9(b), used at $\tilde m$ and at m', gives

$$f_L(\lambda_{\tilde m}) \ge x f_N(\tilde m) - E_1 \ge x f_N(m') - \frac{16x^2H_N}{N^2} - E_1 \ge f_L(\lambda_{m'}) - 2E_1 - \frac{16x^2H_N}{N^2} \ge f_L(\lambda_{\mathrm{L}}) - 2E'.$$

Since $2E' < \kappa_L$, Lemma 3.10(c) gives $(\lambda_{\tilde m} - \lambda_{\mathrm{L}})^2 \le 2E'/\kappa_L$, which is the claim.

Now we prove (b). Let N be large and $\log N \le x \le 2\log N$. Then $x\delta_B$, x/N, $16x^2H_N/N^2$ and $\|f_L''\|_\infty/(8x^2)$ are all at most $\log x/x$, because each is $O(\log^5 N/N)$ or $O(1/\log^2 N)$. So $E' \le C_1 \log x/x$ with an absolute constant C_1. As $\log x/x \le \log\log N/\log N$, for large N we have $E' < \kappa_L/2$. Also (H) holds, $\varepsilon \log N \le 2\log^2 N/N \le \frac{1}{40}$ and $804x\log(x+2) \le N$, so Lemma B.5 gives $m_h \le A_0 x \log^2(x+1) \le N/4$. Hence by (a) $|m^* - x\log x - \lambda_{\mathrm{L}} x| \le x\sqrt{2E'/\kappa_L} \le K\sqrt{x\log x}$ with $K = \sqrt{2C_1/\kappa_L}$, and the same holds for every mode of f_N. At the crossing $x_N = 2\log N - \log\log N + O(1)$ for even N, by Theorem 2.7(b). So $\log N \le x_N \le 2\log N$ for large even N. □

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